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3-yr-old girl raped by school staff in Capital



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Akhilesh's swipe at Cong deepens question over INDIA Bloc unity



FILM: Pg 12

'Salman was keen to star in Raja Shivaji'

GUVERNOR RAVI INVITES SUVENDU TO FORM THE NEW GOVT

Suvendu to script history, take oath today as Bengal's first BJP CM

PRADIP CHATTERJEE

KOLKATA: As Suvendu Adhikari—one of the architects of BJP's stunning Bengal breakthrough—prepares to take oath as the state's ninth Chief Minister and the first ever from the saffron camp, Saturday will mark far more than a routine transfer of power. It will seal one of the most dramatic political transformations in Bengal's history, the BJP's rise from the margins of the state's fiercely ideological politics to the very heart of power.

For the BJP, Adhikari's swearing-in symbolises the end of a decades-long wait to capture Bengal — a state long dominated by the Congress, then Left and later the Trinamool Congress.

The former TMC strongman, who once helped Mamata Banerjee end the Left Front era, will now lead Bengal under the BJP banner after the party's historic victory.

Moreover, Adhikari is set to become only the second Chief Minister from East Midnapore after veteran freedom fighter Ajoy Mukherjee, who had served three brief terms as Bengal's Chief Minister when Midnapore was still an undivided district. The moment adds another layer of political symbolism to an already historic transition of power.



Union Home Minister Amit Shah felicitates West Bengal chief minister-designate Suvendu Adhikari after the BJP legislature party meeting, in Kolkata

Adhikari and his council of ministers are scheduled to take oath at a grand ceremony at Brigade Parade Ground, where a tsunami of BJP workers and supporters are expected to gather to witness the saffron

party formally assume power in Bengal for the first time.

Adhikari's name was proposed at the legislature party meeting at New Town Biswa Bangla Convention Centre and formally announced by

Union Home minister Amit Shah in the presence of newly elected BJP MLAs and senior party leaders.

Shah, who presided over the BJP legislature party meeting, said that all the propos-

als were received in favour of Adhikari before formally announcing Suvendu as the next CM of Bengal.

Describing the process as a unanimous endorsement by the legislators, Shah said eight

THE NARRATIVE

» Suvendu Adhikari is set to become only the second CM from Midnapore after veteran freedom fighter Ajoy Mukherjee, who had served three brief terms as Bengal's Chief Minister when Midnapore was still an undivided district

» 'Enough time was given for a second name, but no other proposal came. Therefore, I announce Suvendu Adhikari as the Chief Minister of West Bengal'

» 'I have known Suvendu ji for a long time. He is a fighter. He understands administration, and he has fought TMC at every step. I am fully confident that together with our team, he will provide good governance in Bengal'

» 'Not I, but we — the BJP government will function on the principle of collective leadership'

Suvendu vows to deliver BJP poll promises, says Bengal enters era of 'trust'



West Bengal BJP Legislative Party Leader Suvendu Adhikari meets West Bengal Governor R. N. Ravi to stake a claim to form the government

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: After his name was announced as the leader of the BJP legislature party by Union Home minister Amit Shah, Bengal chief minister-elect Suvendu Adhikari, in his address at the New Town Biswa Bangla Convention Centre, on Friday, said the first BJP government in the state would deliver the promises made in the party's election manifesto.

He said that the BJP does not believe in words; it only believes in delivering through action. Adhikari also said that the state government would work in coordination with the Centre to realise the aspirations of the people. He said the atmosphere of fear in Bengal had ended and asserted that the state would now move towards an era of 'trust'.

"The people of Bengal have given us a historic mandate. We will fulfil all the promises made in the BJP's poll man-

'BJP WILL DELIVER'

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» Adhikari also said that the state government would work in coordination with the Centre to realise the aspirations of the people. He said the atmosphere of fear in Bengal had ended and asserted that the state would now move towards an era of 'trust'

» The BJP leader was unanimously elected the leader of the BJP legislature party in the presence of Union Home minister Amit Shah and the party's top state leadership

ifesto in Bengal. Our main motto is 'Sabka Sath, Sabka Bikash'. Bhoi (fear) is out and, as Prime Minister Narendra Modi ji has

VIJAY IS EXPECTED TO BE SWORN-IN

Tamil Nadu: Left support takes TVK closer to majority, Vijay meets Guv again

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHENNAI: True to feel-good endings in movies, superstar and TVK chief Vijay is also moving towards a happy ending. Buoyed by the support from the Left parties, Vijay on Friday called on Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar at the Lok Bhavan here and staked claim to form the government, declaring that he has secured support of 118 MLAs, the exact number needed for a majority in the 234-member assembly.

He is expected to take an oath on Saturday, with sources giving a time of 11 am, which the Lok Bhavan is yet to confirm.

According to sources, Vijay sought two weeks to prove his majority — an idea categorically



rejected by the Governor. The Governor asked Vijay why he needed so much time to prove MLAs' support for him.

Vijay hasn't yet decided if other party leaders will take the

TAKEAWAYS

» Left parties, including Communist Party of India (Marxist) and Communist Party of India, extend unconditional support

» Support also indicated by Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi and Indian Union Muslim League

» Congress backs Vijay with support of its 5 MLAs

oath with him, sources added.

Vijay's Tamilaga Vetti Kazhagam swept last month's election; the party won 108 of 234 seats on its debut to break Dravidian giants DMK and

AIADMK's 62-year chokehold on state politics. But the joy of that win dissipated quickly after Governor made it clear he would not invite the TVK leader to form the government without majority support confirmation.

According to Marxist leader and former CPI (M) state secretary K Balakrishnan, besides the two Left parties, VCK and IUML "have also given letters," indicating they too have extended support to TVK, which originally lacked numbers to form government. He claimed Vijay is "being invited" by the governor Arlekar to form government and that he will be sworn-in on Saturday morning.

Hours after the Left parties pledged unconditional support, Vijay

DMK seeks separate LS seating after split with Congress

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) on Friday requested a change in seating for its Members of Parliament in the Lok Sabha following the end of its alliance with the Indian National Congress.

In a letter addressed to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, DMK leader Kanimozhi Karunanidhi said the current arrangement, where DMK MPs sit alongside Congress members, was no longer suitable given the altered political situation.

"I write to respectfully request suitable changes in the seating arrangement of the Members of Parliament belonging to the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam," she said. Referring to the split, Kanimozhi added that "it may not be appropriate for our Members to continue occupying the present seating arrangement alongside them in the House."

'ENOUGH IS ENOUGH'

SC directs MP govt to decide on prosecuting its minister for Col Qureshi remarks

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday criticised the Madhya Pradesh government over its delay in deciding whether to grant sanction to prosecute minister Kunwar Vijay Shah for remarks directed at Army officer Col Sofiya Qureshi in the aftermath of Operation Sindoor.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi expressed strong displeasure, stating, "Enough is enough," while directing the state to comply with its earlier order within four weeks. The matter has been scheduled for hearing after the summer vacation.

During the proceedings, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the state, described Shah's remarks as "unfortunate" and informed the court that the minister had apologised soon after the incident. The bench, however, took a sterner view. "Not unfortunate, but most unfortunate," the Chief Justice said, adding that there appeared to be no genuine sense of remorse.

The court declined to entertain further submissions from Shah's counsel or the state, instead reiterating its January 19 direction that the Madhya Pradesh

US fires on, disables 2 more Iranian tankers as tensions rise in Strait of Hormuz

Washington awaits Tehran's response

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: US forces fired on and disabled two Iranian oil tankers on Friday after exchanging fire with Iranian forces in the Strait of Hormuz overnight. The United Arab Emirates, meanwhile, reported another Iranian missile and drone attack.

The attacks cast more doubt on a tenuous month-old ceasefire that the United States has insisted is still in effect.

Washington is awaiting an Iranian response to its latest proposal for a deal to end the war, reopen the strait and roll back Tehran's disputed nuclear programme.

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said he hopes to receive "a serious offer" from Iran later Friday.

The US military said Friday that its forces had disabled two Iranian tankers that were trying to breach



Oil tankers sit at anchor offshore in the Strait of Hormuz

an American blockade of Iran's ports. Hours earlier, the military said it thwarted attacks on three Navy ships and struck Iranian military facilities in the strait.

Iran has mostly blocked the critical waterway for global energy since the US and Israel launched the war on February 28, causing a global spike in fuel prices and rattling world markets. The US has imposed its own blockade of Iran's ports.

Monsoon: India braces for timely arrival in June despite cool May

Annual cycle links India's rains with Australia's dry phase

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Despite an unusually mild May across much of the country, multiple weather indicators suggest that India's southwest monsoon is advancing on schedule, raising expectations of a timely onset in the coming weeks.

Pre-monsoon activity has already begun to build over southern regions. Thunderstorms have been reported across Tamil Nadu and Kerala, while the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, typically the first Indian territory to experience the monsoon, are about two weeks away from the expected arrival. The India Meteorological Department has projected continued rainfall over Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Kerala and Mahe over the next seven days, noting that thunderstorm activity is likely to intensify through May, a key seasonal signal of monsoon progression. Elsewhere, the transition into



CLOSER LOOK

» May remains unusually cool across large parts of India

» Southwest monsoon signals are strengthening steadily

» Thunderstorms active over Tamil Nadu and Kerala

» Andaman and Nicobar Islands nearing expected monsoon onset within two weeks

» India Meteorological Department forecasts rainfall over southern regions for seven days

» Pre-monsoon thunderstorms expected to intensify through May

NORTH-WEST AND EASTERN INDIA SEE HEAT INTERSPERSED WITH STORMS, LIGHTNING, AND HAIL

the monsoon season is evident through fluctuating weather patterns. Parts of north-west and

eastern India are experiencing alternating spells of heat and sudden thunderstorms

Hantavirus: 2 Indians aboard cruise ship asymptomatic; Centre monitoring situation

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Two Indian nationals aboard the cruise vessel MV Hondius, where a cluster of hantavirus infections has been reported, are asymptomatic and under observation, Union health ministry sources said on Friday, adding that there is no immediate threat to public health in India. Authorities are closely tracking the situation in coordination with global and domestic health agencies as eight probable cases, including five laboratory-confirmed infections and three deaths, have been recorded on the ship.

Information shared under the International Health Regulations framework indicates that the two Indian passengers remain stable and are being monitored as a precaution. Officials said the government is working with the World Health Organization, as well as the National Centre for Disease Control and the Integrated Disease Surveillance Programme, to assess developments and ensure preparedness.

ACCUSED GRANTED BAIL BY COURT

3-yr-old girl raped by school staff in Capital

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A three-year-old girl was allegedly raped by a 57-year-old staff member inside a private school in west Delhi's Janakpuri area, police said on Friday.

The incident came to light on May 1 when the victim's mother filed a complaint at Janakpuri police station, alleging that her daughter was sexually assaulted during school hours by the accused.

According to the complaint, the child had gone to the school on April 30, the second day after her admission.

After returning home, she complained of pain. When questioned by her mother, the girl said that she was taken to an isolated area in the school, where the man allegedly assaulted her.

Based on the complaint, police registered a case under



section 64(1) (punishment for rape) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and section 6 of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act. Police said the child identified the accused, following which the 57-year-old school caretaker was arrested on May 1. He was later produced before a court and sent to judicial custody. However, he was granted bail by a court in Dwaraka on May 7 despite strong opposition from the prosecution. Police said they are checking CCTV footage on the school premises. Meanwhile, the girl's

mother alleged that no proper action was taken immediately after the case was reported. She also said that a school teacher was involved and he was questioned during the police investigation.

She further alleged that the child and family were made to wait for several hours at the police station during the inquiry. Meanwhile, Aam Aadmi Party leader Saurabh Bharadwaj, in a statement, strongly criticised the granting of bail to the 57-year-old caretaker. He also echoed the mother's allegations, claiming that the DCP West threatened the family members instead of cooperating with them.

"Imagine a child being admitted to nursery in a private school and returning home on the very first day, only for the parents to discover that a 57-year-old caretaker raped the child," he said.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi prisons housed 19,512 inmates in 2024 against an authorised capacity of 10,026, with undertrials accounting for 88 per cent of the population, while 858 were serving life imprisonment and 12 were on death row, according to NCRB's Prison Statistics 2024.

According to the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) data detailing the capital's inmate profile, crime categories and prison occupancy levels, inmate population in 2024 comprised 18,758 men, 743 women and 11 transgender persons. Male occupancy stood at 200.7 per cent, while female occupancy was recorded at 109.3 per cent.

Delhi has 14 central jails and two women's jails. The inmate population included 2,232 convicts, 17,178 undertrial prisoners, 12 detainees and 90 inmates categorised under "others".

Undertrials constituted 88 per cent of the total prison population, while convicts



accounted for 11.4 per cent.

Education-wise analysis showed that the largest section of undertrials in Delhi jails had not studied up to Class 10. Of the 17,178 undertrials, 6,949 inmates fell in this category, while 4,657 were illiterate, the data revealed.

Another 1,470 undertrials were graduates, 225 were post-graduates and 160 held technical degrees or diplomas, while 317 had completed Class 10 but had done graduation. Among detainees, six had not completed Class 10, two were illiterate, while one was a graduate.

A detainee is a person taken into custody under preventive laws to deter them from committing a certain crime, often without trial.

Age-wise data showed that most convicts in Delhi prisons belonged to 30-50 yrs age group

The data on terms of sentences showed that life imprisonment was the most common punishment among convicts in Delhi prisons.

A total of 858 convicts were serving life terms, while 413 were serving sentences between 10 and 13 years. Another 348 convicts were serving terms between seven and nine years.

Twelve convicts in Delhi prisons were on death row as on December 31, 2024.

The NCRB data further showed that most inmates lodged in Delhi prisons belonged to the capital itself.

Among convicts, 1,567 belonged to Delhi, while 626 were from other states and 39 were foreign nationals. Among undertrials, 12,522

belonged to Delhi, 3,979 were from other states and 677 were foreign nationals.

Age-wise data showed that most convicts in Delhi prisons belonged to the 30-50 years age group. Of the 2,232 convicts, 1,392 inmates (62.4 per cent) fell in this category, while 450 convicts were aged between 18 and 30 years and 390 were aged 50 years and above.

Among undertrials, the 18-30 years age group formed the largest segment, accounting for 9,938 inmates or 57.9 per cent of the total. Another 6,329 undertrials belonged to the 30-50 years category.

Crime-wise classification showed that among the 1,937 convicts booked under Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and Indian Penal Code (IPC) offences, the largest category was offences affecting the human body, accounting for 1,026 convicts.

This included 792 convicts booked for murder and 129 for attempt to murder.

Delhi prisons also housed 461 convicts booked for offences against women,

including 400 for rape, 33 for insult to modesty and 21 for dowry deaths.

Offences against property accounted for 357 convicts, including cases of robbery, cheating and theft.

Under Special and Local Laws (SLL), Delhi prisons housed 295 convicts, including 107 booked under liquor and narcotics drugs-related provisions and 55 under arms and explosives-related charges.

The NCRB data also highlighted the presence of foreign nationals in Delhi's jails. A total of 724 foreign inmates were lodged in Delhi prisons, including 677 undertrials, 39 convicts and eight detainees. Among them, 587 were men and 137 were women.

Pakistani nationals formed the largest group among foreign convicts at 13, followed by Nigerians at seven and Africans other than Nigerians at five.

Among foreign undertrials, Nigerians formed the largest group at 305, followed by Africans other than Nigerians at 166 and other foreign nationals at 82.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Teen stabbed to death in Bhalswa Dairy

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: An 18-year-old youth was allegedly stabbed to death in north-west Delhi's Bhalswa Dairy area on Wednesday evening, police said.

According to police, a PCR call regarding the incident was received at Bhalswa Dairy Police Station after the victim was brought dead to a hospital by one of his friends. The victim, a resident of Jhuggi Kalandar Colony in Bhalswa Dairy, had sustained serious injuries during an alleged assault near Tandoor Wali Gali around 7.30 pm.

Police said the medico-legal case report indicated suspected stab injuries as the cause of death.

Soon after receiving the information, local police teams and senior officers reached the spot and launched an investigation. The area was cordoned off and examined thoroughly, while crime team and forensic science laboratory officials were called in to collect evidence. During the inspection, police recovered several exhibits from the scene, including two abandoned motorcycles believed to be linked to the crime.

Based on preliminary findings, an FIR under Section 103(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita related to murder was registered at Bhalswa Dairy Police Station. Investigators suspect the attack may have involved multiple persons, though the motive behind the killing is yet to be established. Dedicated teams have been formed to identify and apprehend those involved.

Police are analysing CCTV footage, mobile phone data and other technical evidence, while local intelligence inputs and eyewitness accounts are also being gathered to reconstruct the sequence of events. Further investigation is underway.

Two Meerut residents working at Gr Noida construction site found murdered in hostel

DIPIKA KIROLA

GREATER NOIDA: A double murder was reported at an under-construction hostel of Sitaram Institute in Knowledge Park across Greater Noida on Friday. Two labourers were found dead inside a room on the campus.

Police identified the deceased as Indra, 45, a resident of Abdullapur village in Meerut, and Sheeshpal, 45, from Icholi village in Meerut district. Both men had recently arrived at the construction site for gardening work and were staying in a temporary room within the hostel premises along with another labourer.

According to police offi-



'The 3rd labourer who had been staying with the victims has been missing since the incident and is being traced for questioning'

cials, the incident came to light on Friday morning when fellow workers noticed that the room had remained shut for an unusually long time. Suspecting something amiss, they entered the room and found the two men lying in pools of blood. The police were immediately alerted.

Police teams reached the spot and sealed the area for investigation. A forensic team also collected evidence from the crime scene. Officials said

the victims appeared to have been attacked with a sharp-edged weapon. Blood stains were found splattered inside the room and signs of a struggle indicated that the victims may have tried to resist the attackers.

"The bodies have been sent for postmortem examination. Multiple teams are investigating the case from all angles, including personal rivalry and dispute among workers," a senior police officer said.

GZB: Two workers killed in compressor blast at factory

DIPIKA KIROLA

GHAZIABAD: Two workers were killed and another critically injured after a compressor exploded during testing at a water cooler manufacturing factory in Ghaziabad's Site-4 industrial area under Link Road police station limits on Thursday night.

According to police, the incident took place at Madors Renewal Energy factory, located at plot number 42/25 and owned by Ramesh Sharma. The factory manufactures hot and cold water dispensing machines. Around 18 workers were present when the blast occurred during testing of a machine compressor.

The victims were identified as Imran (27) from Kannauja in Muradnagar, Tribhuvan (46) from Gorakhpur, and Banke Bihari (47), a native of Bihar. Police said the explosion was so powerful that Tribhuvan's hand was severed from his body.



"The compressor suddenly exploded during testing, severely injuring the three technicians. A fire also broke out immediately after the blast," said ACP Sahibabad Amit Saxena.

Fellow workers rushed the injured to a nearby private hospital from where they were referred to Safdarjung Hospital in Delhi due to their critical condition. Imran and Tribhuvan succumbed to injuries during treatment late Thurs-

day night, while Banke Bihari remains critical.

Workers at the factory managed to control the fire using extinguishers and water before fire tenders from Vaishali station could arrive. Fire officials said two fire engines were dispatched but were called back after the blaze was brought under control.

Police said no complaint had been received so far and further action would follow after an inquiry.

Police bust cyber racket posing as Air Force and Army officials

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Crime Branch has busted a sophisticated Mewat-based cyber fraud syndicate that allegedly impersonated senior Indian Air Force and Army officials to cheat businessmen through forged government procurement orders. Four accused linked to the interstate racket operating across Delhi, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh have been arrested.

The accused were identified as Manish (22) from Bulandshahar, Uttar Pradesh; Kaushal (22) from Aligarh, Uttar Pradesh; Amir alias Burhan (24) from Nuh in Haryana's Mewat region; and Rizwan Ahmed (30), also a resident of Nuh. Police said the syndicate allegedly cheated a businessman of over Rs 5 lakh on the pretext of supplying Aluminous Laterite, an industrial-grade material, after sending him fake purchase orders purport-



edly issued by the Indian Air Force. The case surfaced after the complainant approached the Interstate Cyber Cell of the Crime Branch, alleging that he had dispatched the material following repeated communication from persons posing as Air Force officials. After the consignment reached an Air Force station, the victim was allegedly asked to deposit additional money for vendor registration and account mapping on the grounds that his name was not listed as an approved supplier.

An FIR was registered under relevant sections related

to cheating, forgery and impersonation. During investigation, technical surveillance revealed that the SIM cards used in the fraud were issued in Bulandshahar but operated from fixed locations in Nuh district. Acting on these inputs, police arrested Manish and Kaushal for allegedly procuring SIM cards used in the scam, before tracing Amir and Rizwan.

The accused allegedly disclosed that around 30 SIM cards and six bank accounts were procured and supplied to cyber fraudsters to conceal identities while targeting businessmen across states.

Delhi: Gas bill booking scam busted; 2 held

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has arrested two men for allegedly duping a man of around Rs 4.35 lakh in an online gas bill booking scam by coercing him into installing a malicious mobile application, officials said on Friday.

The accused were identified as Vikas Kumar (28), an MBA graduate, and Hardeep Kumar (31), a resident of Ludhiana employed as a school cleaner.

Police said the complainant, Ram Chandra Chopra, received a message on February 28 warning that his gas connection would be disconnected if immediate payment was not made. The caller allegedly convinced him to install a "Gas Bill Application" and shared an APK file through social media.

After the application was installed, the fraudsters allegedly gained remote access to the victim's phone and siphoned off Rs 4.35 lakh through seven transactions in a single day.

PTI

COPS RECOVER PHONES, SIM CARDS, FAKE DOCUS IN RAIDS

Police crack Rs 8 crore cyber fraud syndicate, arrest 14

Accused lured victims with fake work schemes

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has busted an inter-state cyber fraud syndicate, arresting 14 people allegedly linked to fake transactions worth over Rs 8 crore, an official said on Friday.

Police said the accused targeted job seekers through social media platforms, messaging applications and job portals by offering fake work-from-home opportunities, part-time jobs

and lucrative salary packages. "The operation was carried out after a tip-off on April 25 regarding suspicious cyber fraud activities being run from a hotel in the Geeta Colony area," Deputy Commissioner of Police (Shahdara) Rajendra Prasad Meena said.

A police team raided the hotel and found several suspects from different states staying in multiple rooms.

During questioning and searches, police arrested 12 people, and their alleged involvement in an organised cyber fraud racket surfaced, the DCP said. Based on the findings, an FIR was registered, and an investigation was initiated.



During subsequent raids and police custody remand, two more accused, Pardeep alias Alpha and Gevi, were arrested in Punjab's Ludhiana, bringing the total number of arrests to 14, police said.

They said the syndicate members belonged to different states, including Punjab, Telangana, West Bengal, Uttar

Team found the gang used mule bank accounts to transfer, layer cheated money to avoid detection

Pradesh, Bihar, Assam and Madhya Pradesh, and operated through social media groups under the guidance of key handlers, some of whom are based outside India, including Cambodia.

"The team found that the gang used mule bank accounts to transfer and layer cheated money to avoid detection. The

accused's bank account was linked to 40 complaints on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal involving transactions worth around Rs 1.5 crore," the officer said.

He said another ATM card recovered during the operation was allegedly linked to fraud amounting to nearly Rs 3 crore. Police said the accused would first contact victims through calls or messages and lure them with fake employment offers.

They said victims were later shifted to encrypted platforms and shown fabricated company profiles, appointment letters and task-based earning schemes to gain their trust.

The fraudsters allegedly col-

lected money from victims for registration charges, security deposits, investment plans and task completion fees, police said. After receiving substantial payments, they would block victims, they said.

"During the raids, police recovered 18 mobile phones, 19 SIM cards, one laptop, three ATM cards, four cheque books and two stamps allegedly used in the cyber fraud operations," the officer said.

Police said digital evidence, including social media chats and APK-based tools recovered from the accused, indicated a well-organised interstate cyber fraud network. Further investigation is underway.

AIIMS-Delhi to honour neurosurgeon VS Mehta with Lifetime Achievement award

NEW DELHI: The All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), New Delhi, has recommended its prestigious Lifetime Achievement Award to renowned neurosurgeon Prof. (Dr.) VS Mehta for his outstanding contribution to neurosurgery and medical education in India.

The award will be conferred during the 51st Annual Convocation of AIIMS on May 12 at Bharat Mandapam. Vice President Jagdeep Thakur is expected to attend the ceremony as the chief guest.

A former head of the Department of Neurosurgery and chief of the Neurosciences Centre at AIIMS, Prof. Mehta is regarded as one of India's leading neurosurgeons.



Over a career spanning several decades, he played a key role in advancing neurosurgical care, research and academic excellence in the country while mentoring generations of specialists.

Currently serving as Chairman Emeritus, Neurosciences, at Paras Hospital, Gurugram, Prof. Mehta continues to contribute to the field through clinical practice and leadership.

MPPOST

CM REKHA FINDS LACK OF FACILITIES DURING SURPRISE VISIT

Broken basics trigger school safety audit

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Alarmed by complaints of broken toilets, non-functional drinking water systems and poor fire safety arrangements in a government school, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday ordered a comprehensive structural audit of all Delhi government schools, promising strict accountability and immediate corrective action.

The decision came after the Chief Minister conducted a surprise inspection at Government Sarvodaya Vidyalaya, where she interacted directly with students and reviewed the condition of infrastructure and basic facilities.

During the inspection, students informed the Chief Minister that water coolers and RO systems in the school had remained non-functional for a long time, forcing many to drink tap water directly. Several



students also complained about unhygienic toilets, broken doors and irregular water supply. The inspection further revealed that the school's fire safety system was not operational.

Expressing strong displeasure, Gupta reprimanded officials and warned that negligence related to children's safety would not be tolerated. "Had the previous government genuinely strengthened the education system, students would not be

struggling for basic facilities today," she said, taking aim at the previous dispensation's education model.

The Chief Minister announced that all government schools in Delhi would undergo a structural audit to assess the safety and condition of buildings and basic amenities. The audit will cover structural stability, drinking water systems, sanitation, cleanliness and fire safety preparedness.



Calling schools "temples of education," Gupta said the government was committed to ensuring "sensitivity, accountability and fulfilment of students' real needs" within the education system. She added that nearly 700 government schools in Delhi require new buildings or major redevelopment, as many existing structures are 40 to 50 years old and in a dilapidated condition.

Questioning the emphasis

placed on publicity by the previous government, Gupta said, "Advertisements and publicity alone cannot improve education. What matters is ensuring real facilities, a safe environment and quality education for children."

She also directed concerned departments to immediately rectify all safety-related shortcomings identified during the inspection. According to officials, instructions for the city-

Previous government focused on optics, we will deliver real improvement in schools
— CM Rekha

wide audit are being issued, and departments have been asked to prepare detailed reports on infrastructure gaps and urgent requirements.

The Chief Minister said the Delhi government is focusing on result-oriented reforms, including safe infrastructure, hygienic toilets, clean drinking water, smart classrooms and digital facilities for students across the capital's government schools.



Road RADAR to track pollution HOTSPOTS

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major technology-backed crackdown on road dust, garbage burning and other dispersed pollution sources, the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) on Friday launched the "Road Pollution Control" programme, an ambitious citywide mission that will monitor nearly 18,000 km of roads every month through real-time field surveillance.

Operationally named Road RADAR (Real-time Air Pollution Detection Across Roads), the initiative aims to identify pollution hotspots across Delhi using geo-tagged reporting, daily inspections and automated complaint routing to civic agencies. Under the programme, 13 dedicated field surveyors have been deployed across all districts of Delhi to conduct daily road inspections under the jurisdictions of MCD, PWD, NDMC and the Delhi Cantonment Board. Each surveyor has been assigned at least 20 km of roads per day and will log a minimum of 70 geo-tagged pollution-related complaints through the MCD 311 app, creating a citywide target of nearly 1,000 issues daily.

Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said the initiative would strengthen on-ground accountability in Delhi's battle against pollution. "Delhi's fight for clean air must be won on the ground, lane by lane and road by road. Through Road RADAR, the government is introducing a scientific system of daily surveillance, real-time reporting and direct departmental accountability," he said.

The programme will track 11 categories of pollution, including road dust, open garbage burning, plastic burning, construction waste, potholes,

HIGHLIGHTS
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» Each surveyor has been assigned at least 20 km of roads per day and will log a minimum of 70 geo-tagged pollution-related complaints through the MCD 311 app, creating a citywide target of nearly 1,000 issues daily

unpaved roads, unregulated parking areas and dust from construction sites.

Officials said the system includes an automated complaint-routing mechanism under which every issue reported through the app will be directly forwarded to the concerned agency, including MCD, PWD, DDA, CPWD and Indian Railways, without manual intervention.

Calling it a "scientific, accountable and city-wide mission," Sirsa said, "Every pollution source identified must lead to action. Every department must respond, and every agency must remain accountable."

The minister will personally review the programme's progress, with the government aiming to achieve cleaner roads, lower dust levels and measurable improvements in Delhi's air quality through continuous monitoring and enforcement.

Homeopathy, Unani OPD clinics to come up at Delhi hospital

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government will open Homeopathy and Unani OPD clinics at the Chaudhary Brahm Prakash Ayurved Charak Sansthan (CBPACS) to strengthen integrated AYUSH-based wellness and stress management services in the Capital, officials said on Friday.

The initiative will be implemented through the Directorate of AYUSH, Government of NCT of Delhi, with the objective of providing holistic and accessible healthcare services through multiple AYUSH systems, including Ayurveda, Yoga, Homeopathy and Unani, according to an official statement.

Under the arrangement, doctors and supporting staff for the OPD services will be deployed by the Directorate of AYUSH, which will also bear the operational expenditure for the clinics.

CBPACS, an autonomous institute under the Delhi government's health and family welfare department, will provide the required space and institutional support for the functioning of the services. Delhi Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh said the government is committed to strengthening affordable and holistic healthcare services for citizens.

"The introduction of Homeopathy and Unani OPD services at CBPACS will further expand access to integrated AYUSH-based treatment and stress management facilities in the national capital," Singh said.

Officials said the OPD services are expected to support stress management and holistic

'The introduction of Homeopathy and Unani OPD services at CBPACS will further expand access to integrated AYUSH-based treatment and stress management facilities in the national capital'

tic wellness through evidence-based AYUSH (Ayurveda, Yoga and Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha, and Homeopathy) interventions.

Premier research bodies, including the Central Council for Research in Ayurvedic Sciences, Central Council for Research in Unani Medicine, and Central Council for Research in Homoeopathy, have been associated with the initiative to help generate evidence regarding the efficacy of these systems in stress management and holistic healthcare, the statement said.

The government said the move is aimed at strengthening preventive healthcare services by providing patients access to integrated AYUSH treatment systems under one platform.

The initiative is being undertaken under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta as part of efforts to strengthen public healthcare infrastructure and expand access to affordable treatment facilities across different streams of medicine, the statement added.

Temp rises in city days after rains

NEW DELHI: Days after multiple spells of rain brought respite from heat waves in the national capital, the city saw a rise in mercury on Friday, with the Safdarjung station recording 36.4 degrees Celsius, according to the Indian Meteorological Department (IMD).

The day temperature settled at 34.4 degrees Celsius at Palam, five notches below normal, while Lodi Road and Ridge recorded maximums of 34.2 and 34.8 degrees Celsius, respectively.

Ayanagar saw mercury touching 35.1 degrees Celsius, a drop of over five degrees from what is usual for this time of the year. Earlier in the morning, temperatures remained comfortable. The minimum settled at 22.6 degrees Celsius at the base station, Safdarjung, while Palam recorded 20.7 degrees Celsius. The Ridge area was the coolest, recording 20 degrees Celsius, a significant 5.5 degrees below normal.

According to IMD, no rainfall was reported from any part of the city. Data showed 24-hour cumulative rainfall till 8:30 am as nil, with no showers recorded between 8:30 am and 5:30 pm either. Delhi's 24-hour average air quality was recorded in the 'satisfactory' category with the air quality index (AQI) clocked at 100, according to data from the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB). IMD has forecast a minimum temperature of 24 degrees Celsius and a maximum of 36 degrees Celsius with mainly a clear sky.

MP05T

Delhi Assembly observes 32nd Int'l Thalassaemia Day

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Legislative Assembly on Friday observed the 32nd International Thalassaemia Day with an awareness programme organised in collaboration with the National Thalassaemia Welfare Society, where discussions focused on prevention, treatment and policy reforms related to the blood disorder.

Addressing the gathering, Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta said a proposal to make thalassaemia screening mandatory for pregnant women would be taken up for discussion in the House for consideration of a Bill aimed at preventing the birth of children affected with Thalassaemia Major.

The event was attended by former Union Minister Hansraj Gangaram Ahir, senior health experts, doctors, thalassaemia patients and their families.

Ahir said he would raise the issue of ensuring wider access to iron chelation medicines for



thalassaemia patients at the highest level. Medical experts highlighted that around five crore Indians are carriers of the thalassaemia trait, while nearly 12,000 to 15,000 children with Thalassaemia Major are born annually in the country.

Dr. Swaran Anil of the National Thalassaemia Welfare Society urged citizens to donate blood regularly and praised healthcare workers for their dedication toward patients. Senior health officials also highlighted the role of the e-RaktKosh portal in

improving access to blood services across India. General Secretary of the Society, Dr. J.S. Arora, said treatment costs for a thalassaemia patient range from Rs 50,000 to Rs 2 lakh annually, but patients receiving proper blood transfusions and iron chelation therapy can lead near-normal lives.

Experts stressed that Thalassaemia Major can largely be prevented through carrier screening before conception or during early pregnancy, followed by timely antenatal diagnosis and counselling.

CM praises DSGMC president Harmeet Kalka

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday praised Harmeet Singh Kalka for his leadership and contribution to social and religious causes through the Delhi Sikh Gurdwara Management Committee (DSGMC).

Addressing a gathering in the capital, the Chief Minister said Kalka had consistently worked in coordination with the Delhi government and played an important role in promoting social harmony



and community welfare. "He has always worked shoulder to shoulder with the Delhi Government like an elder brother

and has made valuable contributions in the social and religious spheres through collective efforts," Gupta said.

Recalling the events organised last year to mark the 350th martyrdom anniversary of Guru Tegh Bahadur, the Chief Minister said she had the opportunity to closely observe the functioning of DSGMC during the commemorative programmes.

"Since that time, I realised how efficiently, dedicatedly and unitedly the DSGMC team, under the leadership of Har-

meet Singh Kalka, has been serving society and the Sikh faith," she said.

Gupta added that the DSGMC's role extended beyond religious activities and included efforts to strengthen social unity and communal harmony. Calling the organisation's work "inspiring," she said its initiatives serve as an example for society.

On behalf of the Delhi government, the Chief Minister congratulated Kalka and wished him continued success in the future.

Delhi-Faridabad MEMU train service approved

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major boost to regional connectivity, Union Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw has approved the operation of a new Mainline Electric Multiple Unit (MEMU) rail service between Delhi and Faridabad following a request by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta.

Welcoming the decision, the Chief Minister thanked Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Railway Minister, saying the new service would provide major relief to thousands of daily commuters travelling between the two cities for work, education and business.

"A large number of people from Faridabad and nearby areas travel to Delhi every day. The new MEMU service will provide commuters with a faster, affordable and more accessible transport option," Gupta said.

She added that residents had long been demanding improved rail connectivity as the existing transport system often faced overcrowding and delays. According to the Chief Minister, the new ser-

vice would help ease pressure on road traffic while reducing travel time for passengers.

Gupta also said that transport and connectivity projects in Delhi and the National Capital Region were gaining momentum under the "double-engine government," with close coordination between the Centre and the Delhi government.

A MEMU, or Mainline Electric Multiple Unit, is an electric passenger train designed for short- and medium-distance travel on main railway routes. Unlike conventional trains, MEMU services operate without a separate locomotive and are powered through motor coaches, allowing faster acceleration and smoother operation on routes with frequent stops.

Officials said MEMU trains generally run at speeds of 100-110 kmph and are equipped with modern facilities such as LED lighting, GPS-based passenger information systems, bio-toilets, CCTV cameras and energy-efficient technology, making them a convenient option for officegoers, students and regular commuters.

Min launches ₹70L dev works in Sonia Vihar

NEW DELHI: Delhi Minister Kapil Mishra on Friday inaugurated road and drain construction projects worth Rs 70 lakh in Sonia Vihar and dedicated newly completed link lanes to the public, while also launching a sharp political attack on previous governments over the condition of infrastructure in unauthorised colonies.

Speaking at the inauguration at Third Pushta Market, Mishra said development work in Karawal Nagar had accelerated under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta. "Karawal Nagar has received development projects worth Rs 300 crore in the very first year," he said.

The minister said sewer network work worth nearly Rs 70 crore was currently underway in Sonia Vihar and similar work in Sabhapur would begin within a month. According to him, 70 to 80 per cent of the sewer work in Sonia Vihar has already been completed in about a year, which would help solve problems of waterlogging and damaged roads.

Targeting earlier administrations, Mishra said, "Under previous governments, representatives used to spend five years merely dumping debris in unauthorised colonies, leaving lanes dug up for years." He added that the present government was focused on result-oriented development and improving civic infrastructure.

The minister also referred to the completion of one year of "Operation Sindoor", praising Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Indian Armed Forces. "Through 'Operation Sindoor', the Army created such fear among terrorists that even those who demanded proof are now extending congratulations," he said.

MP05T

SECOND LEG OF CARIBBEAN VISIT

Partnerships critical for progress in ‘tough world’: EAM Jaishankar

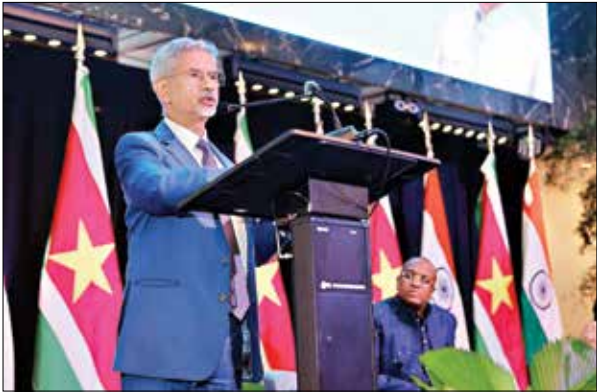
PARAMARIBO: External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar stressed the critical role of partnerships in achieving progress in a “tough world,” and underlined India’s role as a “trusted” partner in the global context.

Jaishankar made the remarks while addressing representatives from sections of Suriname’s society on the theme ‘Partnership for Progress’ in Paramaribo on Thursday. The minister is here on the second leg of his three-nation Caribbean visit.

“Made the case that a tough world nevertheless requires progress. And that is best achieved through partnerships,” he said in a post on X.

In his address, the minister said that the decade began with the COVID-19 pandemic, followed by the Ukraine conflict and the ongoing war in West Asia.

“The term ‘tough world’



External Affairs minister S Jaishankar speaks on the theme ‘Partnership for Progress’ during a programme organised by Suriname’s Ministry of Foreign Affairs, in Paramaribo

is a bit of an understatement. We are seeing today a weaponisation of finance, resources, technology, connectivity, geography,” Jaishankar said.

In such times, nations would like to see progress in terms of a more inclusive world, sustainable growth, and more respect

in international politics.

He highlighted the characteristics of a trusted partner who can reconcile national interest with global good.

“One of the characteristics of a good partner is a nation which is able to harmonise its national interest with a commit-

Highlights

» Jaishankar said that the decade began with the COVID-19 pandemic, followed by the Ukraine conflict and the ongoing war in West Asia

» Jaishankar highlighted the characteristics of a trusted partner who can reconcile national interest with global good

alism, and has a caring attitude towards the planet.

He also described India’s role in global politics in that context, focusing on development partnerships, global work-force, first responder record, and new initiatives.

“It is this India that will partner Suriname in its growth trajectory and jointly write the next chapter of the India-Suriname story,” Jaishankar said on X. “It is a tough world, but we need progress, we need partnerships, they do exist...we’ll keep doing that with a high degree of commitment and determination,” he said in his address.

Surinamese Foreign Minister Melvin Bouva was present at the event organised by the Caribbean nation’s foreign ministry. Later in the day, Jaishankar also planted a sapling at India House in Suriname under the ‘Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam’ initiative.

Suvendu to script history, take oath...

Continued from Page 1
Therefore, I announce Suvendu Adhikari as the Chief Minister of West Bengal,” Shah said after the meeting. Suvendu Adhikari was unanimously elected leader of the BJP legislature party in West Bengal on Friday, formally paving the way for him to become the state’s first-ever BJP Chief Minister.

Hours after being elected leader of the BJP legislature party, Suvendu Adhikari reached Lok Bhavan on Friday evening with letters of support from BJP MLAs to stake claim to form the government. Following his meeting with Governor RN Ravi, Adhikari was formally invited to take oath as Bengal’s next Chief Minister at Brigade Parade Ground on May 9.

The development came a day after Governor Ravi dissolved the state Assembly, clearing the decks for the formation of a new government after Mamata Banerjee refused to resign following the BJP’s sweeping victory.

The BJP had finalised May 9 as the day for swearing in as it coincided with “Pochishe Baisakh” (Rabindranath Tagore’s Jayanti) in the Bengali calendar.

BJP spent the entire campaign assuring Bengalis that it understood their culture, their language,

and their soul and now, by choosing Tagore’s birth anniversary for the swearing-in, would be an attempt to send across a message.

Shah, on Friday, also invoked Tagore while addressing the BJP’s legislature party members in Kolkata. He said that the BJP government in the state would make way for people to live with their “minds without fear and head held high” referring to the Nobel Laureate’s famous poem ‘Where the mind is without fear’.

Shah also took a sharp dig at Trinamool supremo Mamata Banerjee, while announcing Adhikari’s name, saying she had been defeated on her home turf, Bhowanipore. “Suvendu da ne ghar mein aa ke haraya (Suvendu da came to your home turf and defeated you),” Shah said, underscoring Adhikari’s victory in Bhowanipore. Congratulating Adhikari, Shah said he was confident the BJP leader would provide stable governance and fulfil the aspirations of Bengal’s people.

“I have known Suvendu ji for a long time. He is a fighter. He understands administration, and he has fought TMC at every step. I am fully confident that together with our team, he will provide good governance in Bengal. The struggle he undertook has now yielded results.

‘The sacrifices of over 321 workers have borne fruit today,’ Shah said. “The ideological journey that began in 1950 under the leadership of Syama Prasad Mookerjee has, in 2026, finally brought his party to power in his own birthplace. This is deeply significant,” Shah added.

During his speech, Adhikari expressed his gratitude to PM Modi, Home minister Amit Shah.

“I express gratitude to Amit Shah. With the blessings of the Prime Minister, I have been elected as the Leader of the Legislature Party. I have received support from all MLAs. There is democracy in the BJP. We will fulfil the commitment of the BJP made during the election campaigns,” Adhikari added. “Bhoi is out, and bharosa is in,” Adhikari declared, echoing Modi’s campaign slogan and drawing loud cheers from party workers. Making it clear that the incoming administration would function collectively, Adhikari said: “Not ‘I’, but ‘we’ — the BJP government will function on the principle of collective leadership.”

Modi, Shah, BJP’s national president Nitin Nabin, a host of Union ministers and chief ministers of BJP-ruled states will attend the swearing-in ceremony on Saturday. The oath-taking ceremony is likely to begin at around 11 am.

From Page 1

Suvendu vows

said,” Adhikari said amid loud cheers from the BJP’s winning candidates and supporters. “We will try our best to fulfil all the responsibilities people of Bengal have given to us,” he added.

Earlier in the day, the senior BJP leader was unanimously elected the leader of the BJP legislature party in the presence of Union Home minister Amit Shah and the party’s top state leadership, paving the way for him to become the first BJP chief minister of West Bengal.

Stressing the need for coordination between the Centre and the new BJP government in the state, Adhikari said: “Let the Centre and the state work together to fulfil the aspirations of the people of Bengal.”

Adhikari also gave the credit for the BJP’s spectacular victory in Bengal to the party workers who fought against all odds. He also gave due credit to state BJP president Samik Bhattacharya.

Vijay meets

reached the office of the governor in Guindy and TVK supporters broke into celebrations here and elsewhere in the state.

Vijay-led Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam, with 108 seats but 10 short of a majority initially, had earlier reached out to CPI, CPI (M) and the VCK-- all DMK allies, seeking their support to form government after winning its maiden Assembly election in Tamil Nadu. The CPI and CPI (M) have extended support to Vijay, while VCK will announce its decision on Saturday.

Vijay later visited the offices of the CPI and CPI-M and thanked the Left leaders for their support to his party to form the government.

Left parties have asserted that they will support the TVK form government but also continue their “journey” with the DMK.

CPI State Secretary M Veerapandian said “people have proposed democracy and we have seconded it,” and we extend support to TVK.

As regards protection of the state’s rights and similar issues, the Left parties will continue to align with the DMK, CPI(M) State Secretary P Shanmugam said.

Welcoming the outgoing Chief Minister M K Stalin’s statement urging Governor Arlekar to immediately take necessary steps to ensure that a new government is formed as per the Constitution, IUMI cryptically said, “Its 2 MLAs would support the initiatives by the Governor towards the government formation.” The statement by IUMI, top leader Prof KM Kader Mohideen is seen as a hint that IUMI shall “facilitate” government formation by TVK.

Vijay will have to resign from one of the two constituencies he has won, as per EC norms. Congress party has extended the support of its five MLAs to Vijay. As per the calculations, the strength of TVK and its supporting MLAs now stands at 116, including the requirement of Vijay resigning from one of the

two seats he contested from-- Perambur in Chennai and Tiruchirappalli East.

While the CPI initially informed the Tamil Nadu Governor of their decision to support TVK, CPI (M) followed suit shortly, bringing Vijay closer to the simple majority mark. Both parties addressed letters to the governor informing of their support to the TVK.

Addressing a joint press conference, CPI(M) State Secretary P Shanmugam and CPI State Secretary M Veerapandian, declared unconditional support to the TVK.

Shanmugam said the decision to support TVK was to prevent BJP’s “backdoor entry” into Tamil Nadu. It was to prevent its bid to rule the state through Governor though it has lost polls.

“If no government is formed within 10 days, it may lead to imposition of governor’s rule. As regards protection of the state’s rights, the Left parties will continue to align with the DMK,” Shanmugam said.

Meanwhile, Viduthalai Chiduthaigal Katchi (VCK) said it will hold an online meeting later on Friday to discuss the matter, although it was expected that the discussion would be held in the morning.

VCK founder Thol Thirumavalavan said the party’s high-level committee will meet via video conferencing on Friday evening to discuss the prevailing “political crisis” in Tamil Nadu and decide on the party’s future course of action regarding government formation.

CPI, CPI (M) and VCK are part of the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance (SPA).

Responding to queries about his recent meeting with DMK president and outgoing Chief Minister M K Stalin, the VCK leader maintained that the party remains part of the SPA. He described the meeting with Stalin as a courtesy call between alliance partners.

Meanwhile, the Congress staged a protest against the Governor over not inviting TVK chief Vijay to form the government. Tamil Nadu Congress Committee president K Selvaperunthagai, AICC in-charge for Tamil Nadu and Puducherry Girish Chodanar, and party workers participated in the agitation held here.

US fires on

The UAE’s Defence Ministry meanwhile said three people were wounded after air defences engaged two ballistic missiles and three drones launched by Iran. It was not clear if all were successfully intercepted.

The US military posted video of the two Iranian tankers as their smokestacks were struck by an American fighter jet on Friday.

Earlier in the week, an American military jet shot out the rudder of a tanker the US military said was attempting to breach its blockade.

Late Thursday, the US military said it thwarted Iranian attacks on three Navy ships in the Strait of Hormuz and struck Iranian military facilities in response. It said no American ships were hit.

“They threaten Americans, they are going to be blown up,” Rubio told reporters Friday.

Iran’s Foreign Ministry con-

demned what it called “hostile” US military action, saying it violated the ceasefire. “Every time a diplomatic solution is on the table, the US opts for a reckless military adventure,” Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi posted on X.

A US strike overnight killed at least one sailor and injured 10 others aboard a cargo vessel that caught fire, a news agency affiliated with Iran’s judiciary reported. It was not clear if the ship was one of the two tankers the US acknowledged striking.

US President Donald Trump has insisted the ceasefire is holding. He also has reiterated threats to resume full-scale bombing if Iran doesn’t accept an agreement to reopen the strait and roll back its nuclear programme.

Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said his country has been in contact with the US and Iran “day and night” in an effort to extend the ceasefire and reach a peace deal.

Satellite images reviewed by The Associated Press show what appears to be an oil slick in the Persian Gulf emanating from the western side of Kharg Island, Iran’s main crude export terminal.

The images taken Wednesday show the slick covering roughly 95 square kilometres. Windward AI, a maritime intelligence firm, said it first detected the spill in satellite images taken Tuesday and the slick was spreading southwest at a rate of about 2 kilometres an hour.

“If the slick continues drifting southward, there could also be risks to ecologically sensitive and protected marine areas in the Gulf,” said Nina Noelle, an international crisis operations expert with Greenpeace Germany.

The Pentagon declined to comment on whether the US military was tracking the spill or whether there had been recent strikes on the Iranian island. Based on the imagery taken earlier this week, the spill occurred before the most recent round of US strikes.

Rubio said Friday that it’s “unacceptable” for Iran to have a government agency that vets and taxes ships seeking passage through the strait.

Lloyd’s List Intelligence, a shipping data company, reported Thursday that Iran has created such an agency, known as the Persian Gulf Strait Authority.

The Iranian effort to formalize control over the channel raised new concerns about international shipping, with hundreds of commercial vessels bottled up in the Persian Gulf and unable to reach the open sea.

“Is the world going to accept that Iran now controls an international waterway?” Rubio said. “What is the world prepared to do about it?”

Iran has effectively closed the strait, a vital waterway for the shipment of oil, gas, fertiliser and other petroleum products, while the US is blockading Iranian ports.

A Chinese-crewed oil tanker was attacked near the strait. China has continued to import oil from Iran despite the effective closure of the waterway.

China’s Foreign Ministry expressed concern, saying the tanker was registered in the Marshall Islands with Chinese crew on board. There were no casualties reported.

An oil tanker that passed through the Strait of Hormuz

in mid-April arrived off South Korea’s coast on Friday with 1 million barrels of crude. South Korea, which last year imported more than 60 per cent of its crude through the strait, has capped prices of gasoline and other petroleum products.

SC directs

government must take a decision on granting sanction for prosecution. “You comply with the directions given in paragraphs five and six of our previous order,” the bench told the state.

The case stems from comments made by Shah, which led to an investigation by a court-appointed Special Investigation Team. The SIT has completed its probe and submitted a final report. However, further proceedings have been held up pending the state’s approval under Section 196 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, which deals with offences related to promoting enmity and ill-will.

The apex court had earlier examined the SIT’s findings in a sealed cover and noted that the panel recommended prosecution after reviewing various aspects of the case. It also directed the SIT to investigate additional instances attributed to Shah and file a separate status report.

Senior advocate Maninder Singh, representing Shah, reiterated that the minister had issued a prompt apology. Mehta, while clarifying he was not defending Shah, suggested that the minister may have intended to praise the officer but failed to articulate his thoughts properly. The court, however, remained unconvinced, observing that public figures are generally careful with their words and can apologise swiftly if a statement is a genuine slip.

The controversy dates back to a widely circulated video in which Shah allegedly made objectionable remarks about Col Qureshi, who had gained national attention alongside Wing Commander Vyomika Singh during briefings related to Operation Sindoor. The Madhya Pradesh High Court had earlier criticised Shah’s comments as “scurrilous” and directed the police to register an FIR on charges of promoting enmity.

In previous hearings, the Supreme Court had questioned Shah’s conduct, noting in July 2025 that he was “testing the court’s patience” by not placing a formal public apology on record. Despite Shah later expressing regret and stating that he respected Col Qureshi “more than his sister”, the court has continued to scrutinise the matter closely.

Hantavirus

Preliminary findings suggest that the infections are linked to the Andes strain of hantavirus, which has limited potential for human-to-human transmission and typically requires prolonged close contact. The WHO, which was notified in early May, has assessed the overall public health risk as low, although it has cautioned that additional cases could emerge due to the virus’s relatively long incubation period.

Reinforcing this assessment, Naveen Kumar, director of the Indian Council of Medi-

cal Research’s National Institute of Virology, said the cases appear isolated. “The reported hantavirus cases appear to be isolated ones and there is no immediate public health threat to India,” he said, noting that there is no evidence of community spread.

Hantaviruses are primarily transmitted through contact with infected rodents or their bodily fluids. Kumar explained that infection often occurs when people inhale virus particles from rodent urine, droppings or saliva, particularly in enclosed or poorly ventilated environments such as ships, warehouses or storage facilities. He added that, unlike COVID-19, human-to-human transmission is extremely rare and has only been documented in limited cases involving certain South American strains.

WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus described the situation as serious but contained. “While this is a serious incident, WHO assesses the public health risk as low,” he said, adding that more cases may still be reported.

Indian authorities have convened a high-level review through the Public Health Emergency Operations Centre to evaluate readiness. Officials highlighted that the country has sufficient diagnostic capacity, with a network of 165 laboratories equipped for RT-PCR testing to detect hantavirus infections.

Experts said early symptoms can resemble flu-like illness, including fever, headache, fatigue and nausea, making detection challenging. Severe cases may involve breathing difficulties or kidney complications.

Health officials have advised travellers and workers in rodent-prone environments to maintain hygiene and avoid exposure. They also warned that environmental factors such as climate change, flooding and rapid urbanisation could increase the long-term risk of rodent-borne diseases, though there is currently no indication of wider transmission linked to the cruise ship cluster.

Monsoon

accompanied by lightning and hail, conditions typically associated with a seasonal shift.

Current forecasts indicate that the monsoon is likely to reach the Kerala coast around June 1, in line with its normal schedule.

Meteorologists are also tracking developments beyond the Indian subcontinent. Australia’s Bureau of Meteorology recently announced the conclusion of the 2025–26 northern Australian wet season, a development that plays a role in the broader dynamics of the Asian monsoon system.

The end of Australia’s wet season is considered a significant marker because it allows a large band of clouds and rainfall near the equator to shift northward. This system, often described as a global belt of rain, migrates with the Sun’s position and is responsible for delivering seasonal rainfall across different regions.

With rainfall activity receding in the Southern Hemisphere, this belt is now moving across the equator toward South Asia. Meteorological observations indicate that it has already passed the equatorial region and is advancing beyond the Maldives toward

Sri Lanka and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands.

As the system moves further north, it draws moisture-laden winds from surrounding oceans, setting the stage for the monsoon’s arrival over India. The process is part of a recurring annual cycle, during which India receives rainfall from May to September, while Australia enters a dry phase.

By late September, the pattern reverses, with the rain belt shifting southward again, marking the withdrawal of the Indian monsoon and the onset of Australia’s wet season.

For now, weather patterns remain aligned, and early indicators point to a steady advance of the monsoon toward the Indian mainland.

State oil firms

imports, 90 per cent of LPG and 65 per cent of natural gas.

Even so, there has been no rationing, shortage or supply disruption across India over the past 10 weeks. Oil companies ramped up operations to meet demand, including spikes triggered by panic buying.

At a media briefing, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, said international price fluctuations and supply constraints had put pressure on the system. “It has been government’s endeavour to keep prices stable so far and that there is no price increase for consumers,” she said, adding that “monthly under-recoveries are of the order of Rs 30,000 crore.”

She did not confirm whether the current pricing policy would continue, stating only that the focus so far has been on shielding consumers.

The losses stem from the gap between rising input costs and fixed retail prices. During April, under-recoveries were estimated at about Rs 18 per litre on petrol and Rs 25 per litre on diesel. These losses had peaked in March and April before easing slightly.

To mitigate the burden, the government reduced excise duties. The special additional excise duty on petrol was cut from Rs 13 per litre to Rs 3, while diesel duty was reduced from Rs 10 per litre to zero. Without these cuts, monthly under-recoveries could have reached approximately Rs 62,500 crore.

The Centre itself is absorbing a significant portion of the impact. According to Sharma, excise duty reductions have led to a revenue hit of around Rs 14,000 crore per month. At peak crude prices, the government’s effective absorption was estimated at Rs 24 per litre for petrol and Rs 30 per litre for diesel.

Oil companies are also facing additional operational costs due to emergency sourcing of crude, higher freight rates from rerouted shipments, increased marine insurance premiums and refinery adjustments.

Sources said the decision to hold retail prices reflects a broader policy objective of maintaining economic stability during a global energy shock. However, they cautioned that prolonged high crude prices could lead to increased borrowing needs and potential adjustments to capital expenditure plans.

Investments tied to refining

capacity expansion, energy security infrastructure, ethanol blending, biofuels and transition fuels are expected to continue with government support.

Sharma noted that revenues generated by oil companies are critical for purchasing crude, building refining infrastructure and maintaining supply networks. “Their capex spending is all dependent on the revenues they earn,” she said.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

DMK seeks

She urged the Speaker to allocate separate seating for DMK MPs so they could carry out their parliamentary duties effectively.

The development follows a breakdown in ties between the two parties after the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections. The Congress, which secured just five seats, has extended support to the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) in forming the government, ending its longstanding partnership with the DMK.

The Congress had contested the elections as part of a pre-poll alliance with the DMK, making the post-election move a point of contention. Senior DMK leaders have criticised the decision, describing it as “backstabbing” and “betrayal.”

Congress leaders have defended their stance, noting that the DMK had chosen to contest the 2014 elections independently, arguing that political alignments can shift based on circumstances.

Outrage over ‘Sangam’ liquor name, seers threaten agitation if not withdrawn

OUR CORRESPONDENT

PRAYAGRAJ: Seers have expressed strong displeasure over a liquor company selling alcohol under the brand name ‘Sangam’, apparently named after the sacred confluence of the rivers Ganga, Yamuna, and the ancient Saraswati, threatening agitation if the liquor brand is not removed from the market.

The seers are protesting against the name ‘Sangam World Malt Whisky’, launched in 2024 and produced by Radico Khaitan Limited (formerly Rampur Distillery).

Jagatguru Ramanujacharya Shandilya Maharaj, while addressing reporters at the Bhadravaj Ashram on Friday, said, “In our Sanatan Dharma, the confluence of the rivers Ganga, Yamuna, and Saraswati, located in Prayagraj, is called Sangam. The Sangam area is highly revered around, and people from all over the world collect water from here. Today, the situation has reached such a point that a liquor company is selling alcohol in the name of Sangam.”

He added that seers are outraged with the liquor company.

KERALA CM PICK

Congress observers submit report to party chief Kharge



A man rides past posters supporting KC Venugopal and VD Satheesan near the Congress headquarters, in Thiruvananthapuram, Friday

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The two Congress observers, appointed to seek the opinion of newly-elected MLAs in Kerala, submitted their report to Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Friday and urged the party high command to take a final decision on the chief ministerial candidate.

Ajay Maken and Mukul Wasnik spoke to all the MLAs of the Congress as well as party MPs and submitted their observations to the party leadership. The duo had gone to Kerala on Wednesday and met all the legislators and MPs on Thursday before returning to the national capital.

Sources said a majority of the party MLAs are in support of making AICC general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal the chief minister while the public is favouring senior party leader V D Satheesan, who was the leader of Opposition in the outgoing Kerala Assembly.

Maken and Wasnik discussed with Kharge the observations made by the new party

Sources said majority of party MLAs supporting K C Venugopal as the chief minister while the public is favouring V D Satheesan

legislators when they met each one of the them individually. They have also spoken to the party MPs and some ex-MPs, the sources said.

Besides Venugopal and Satheesan, senior party leader Ramesh Chennithala is also in the race for chief ministership.

The sources said Kharge has called all the three contenders for talks before taking a final decision.

They said Venugopal is also keen on assuming the role of chief minister and is using his influence with the party leadership for the selection. His proximity to Rahul Gandhi is also well known and that may come in his favour.

Akhilesh's swipe at Cong deepens question over INDIA Bloc unity

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Friday appeared to take a veiled swipe at Congress after the party's dramatic political shift in Tamil Nadu triggered fresh questions over the stability of the INDIA Bloc.

Sharing a photograph from his recent meeting with Trinamool Congress supremo Mamata Banerjee and another picture with DMK president M K Stalin, Akhilesh posted on social media platform X, "We are not the ones who abandon each other in times of difficulty."

Though he did not directly name Congress, the timing of the remark quickly drew attention in political circles after the party walked out of its long-standing alliance with the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam in Tamil Nadu and extended support to actor-politician Vijay and his Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam (TVK).

Akhilesh's remarks came



a day after he met Mamata Banerjee and TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee in Kolkata following the Trinamool Congress' setback in West Bengal.

The meeting was seen as part of wider Opposition efforts to reassess political strategy after recent Assembly election losses.

The Congress on Wednesday announced support to Vijay's TVK in a surprise move that effectively ended its alliance with the DMK, a partner it had remained aligned with for years in Tamil Nadu politics.

The Tamil Nadu Congress Committee said it would support the formation of a TVK-led government and "share the responsibility of governance".

Shah to chair high-level meeting on flood and heatwave preparedness

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Union Home minister Amit Shah will chair a high-level meeting in New Delhi on Sunday to review the country's preparedness for possible floods and heatwave conditions.

The discussion unfolds at the national level, guided by federal oversight.

Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's direction, efforts to manage disasters now involve every government branch along with public participation. This gathering takes place within that broader framework.

The evaluation aims to examine readiness across central agencies, beginning with how warnings are issued. When gaps appear, attention

shifts to the movement of supplies and personnel. Coordination between departments becomes a focus where overlaps occur.

The safety of lives stands as the primary concern throughout. Property protection follows closely in priority. Outcomes depend on timing, structure, and clarity under pressure.

Recently, coordination among federal and regional authorities has improved under guidance from the Ministry of Home Affairs. The National Disaster Response Force now reaches further into vulnerable regions. With emphasis placed firmly on preventing loss of life during emergencies, operational methods have evolved gradually.

Now infiltration, cow smuggling impossible: Shah

Home minister describes the BJP's emphatic victory in West Bengal as far more than an electoral milestone

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Friday said infiltration and cattle smuggling would become "impossible" in West Bengal under the BJP government, as he formally announced Suwendu Adhikari as the leader of the BJP legislature party and the party's chief ministerial face.

Addressing BJP MLAs and senior leaders at a charged legislature party meeting here, Shah described the party's emphatic victory in West Bengal as far more than an electoral milestone, portraying it as a decisive political shift tied to national security, democratic restoration and the ideological culmination of a journey that began with Syama Prasad Mookerjee in the early Fifties.

"Friends, this victory is not merely about BJP's expansion or its ideology. Nor is it only about BJP-NDA forming a government in its 21st state. The biggest importance of this victory is that it plugs one of the biggest holes in India's national security. Now infiltration and



Union Home minister Amit Shah addresses after the BJP legislature party meeting, in Kolkata, Friday

cow smuggling will become impossible in West Bengal," Shah asserted.

"The BJP promises the people of Bengal and the country that we will identify and remove every infiltrator from India. And let me say from this stage -- people who call this polarisation are mistaken. This is not about polarisation. This is about national security," he said.

The BJP's victory in West Bengal marks the end of the Trinamool Congress's 15-year rule and brings the saffron party to power in a state long considered a politically challenging terrain.

Invoking symbolism deeply rooted in Bengal's political and

Highlights

- » 'The biggest importance of this victory is that it plugs one of the biggest holes in India's national security'
- » The BJP promises the people of Bengal and the country that we will identify and remove every infiltrator from India, said Shah
- » BJP's victory in Bengal marks the end of the TMC's 15-year rule and brings the saffron party to power

cultural history, Shah said the BJP government now stretched "from Gangotri to Gangasagar" and linked the victory to the ideological legacy of Jana Sangh founder Mookerjee.

"The ideological journey that began in 1950 under the leadership of Syama Prasad Mookerjee has, in 2026, finally brought his party to power in his own birthplace. This is deeply significant," he said.

He also referred to the 150th year of Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay's 'Vande Mataram', saying the BJP forming government on the novelist's land was "a huge sign".

Launching a broadside against the outgoing TMC

regime, Shah alleged that Mamata Banerjee's tenure had witnessed the "politicisation of administration" and "criminalisation of politics", while violence, syndicates, corruption and "cut money" had become entrenched.

"Under Mamata ji's 15 years of rule, administration became thoroughly politicised, and politics became criminalised. Criminals themselves became politicians. There was no possibility of good governance," he claimed.

"Goondaism, violence, syndicates, corruption, and cut money -- all these have become a curse on Bengal. Within months of our new CM

taking charge, all this will end," Shah said.

Promising a "double-engine government", Shah said Bengal's development had been stalled because Central schemes and funds were blocked for political reasons.

"For years, the Centre wanted Bengal's development, but funds and schemes were blocked because of fear that Modi ji would become more popular. Today, after a long time, the lotus blooms both at the Centre and in the state. Now no one can stop Bengal's development," he said.

The home minister also attempted to project the BJP's Bengal victory as a mandate for democratic normalcy after decades of politically linked violence. "I appeal to all political parties -- elections are a celebration of democracy. Why should violence occur in them? Violence must end across India, and BJP has a special responsibility in this regard," he said.

"Let us take a resolve and appeal to all parties that there should be no violence in polls. It will be BJP government's respon-

sibility that there should not be a single incident of violence or malpractices in elections," Shah added.

Recalling repeated allegations by the Opposition over electoral manipulation, Shah attacked the Congress and Rahul Gandhi over their criticism of EVMs and voter lists.

"Rahul Gandhi ji talks about EVMs, voter theft, voter lists and SIR only to hide his defeats," he said.

He also sought to showcase the BJP's social outreach by citing newly elected women legislators, including Rachna Debnath from Panihati, Rekha Patra from Sandeshkhali and Kavita Manjhi.

Shah also framed the Bengal mandate as part of a larger political consolidation of eastern India under the BJP, saying the region had rejected parties that kept it deprived of growth and investment for decades.

"In 2014, Modi ji had said eastern India must develop equally with western India. Today, Bengal, Assam, Odisha and the entire eastern belt have come under the BJP flag," he said.

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JOINT COMMANDERS CONFERENCE

Rajnath to forces: Integrate surprise element in warfare

MPOST BUREAU

JAIPUR/NEW DELHI: Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Friday directed the top military commanders of the three services to integrate an “element of surprise” into modern warfare to outmanoeuvre India’s adversaries and bolster strategic posture.

In his address at the joint commanders conference in Jaipur, Singh also described the Operation Sindoor as a testament to the ‘swift, precise, and joint response’ of the Indian armed forces to safeguard national interests and called upon the military to remain ready to deal with any security challenges.

In their two-day deliberations, the commanders carried out a comprehensive review of the combat preparedness of the military in the wake of the evolving regional security



Defence minister Rajnath Singh addresses the joint commanders' conference commemorating the first anniversary of Operation Sindoor, in Jaipur

situation.

Operation Sindoor was a demonstration of India’s growing capabilities and a symbol of the nation’s collective resolve and new military ethos, Singh said, a day after the first anniversary of Operation Sindoor.

He also unveiled a ‘Joint

Doctrine for Integrated Communication Architecture’ that is aimed at strengthening doctrinal clarity, interoperability and integrated communications across the armed forces in future multidomain operations.

The joint commanders’ conference, themed ‘Military Capa-

HIGHLIGHTS

» Singh also described the Op Sindoor as a testament to the ‘swift, precise, and joint response’ of the Indian armed forces

» In their two-day deliberations, the commanders carried out a comprehensive review of the combat preparedness of the military

bility in New Domains’, brought together the top leadership of the defence ministry and the three services to deliberate on emerging security challenges and future readiness.

Comprehensive deliberations were held on future warfare, multidomain opera-

tions, technological transformation and joint capability development.

The conference witnessed extensive discussions on cognitive warfare, cyber resilience against evolving quantum and AI-enabled threats, military capability development in emerging domains, indigenous innovation and AI-enabled warfighting concepts.

It was attended by Chief of Defence Staff Gen Anil Chauhan, Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Dinesh Kumar Tripathi, Chief of the Army Staff Gen Upendra Dwivedi, Chief of the Air Staff Air Chief Marshal AP Singh and Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh among others.

In his remarks, Singh asked the commanders to remain “future-ready” by learning from the operation as well as the current global security landscape.

Crimes against children continue to rise: NCRB

Data: 9 in 10 cybercrimes against children involve explicit content

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Nearly nine out of every 10 cybercrimes against children in India in 2024 involved transmitting sexually explicit content depicting children, according to National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) data.

The latest NCRB figures showed that crimes against children continued to rise despite an overall decline in crimes across the country.

A total of 1,87,702 cases of crimes against children were recorded across India in 2024, up 5.8 per cent from 1,77,335 cases in 2023.

In contrast, overall crimes in India declined by nearly 10.8 per cent over the last four years, from 66.01 lakh cases in 2020 to 58.86 lakh cases in 2024.

During the same period, crimes against children rose sharply from 1,28,531 cases in 2020 to 1,87,702 cases in

A total of 1,87,702 cases of crimes against children were recorded across India in 2024, up 5.8% from 1,77,335 cases in 2023

2024, marking a worrying spike of over 46 per cent.

An analysis of the latest NCRB data by CRY – Child Rights and You shows 1,238 cases were registered under the Information Technology Act in connection with cybercrimes against children in 2024, accounting for nearly 0.7 per cent of all crimes against children.

Of these, 1,099 cases involved publishing or transmitting material depicting children in sexually explicit

acts, while all other categories together accounted for only 139 cases.

According to CRY’s analysis of state-wise NCRB data, Chhattisgarh recorded the highest number of cybercrimes against children with 268 cases, followed by Rajasthan (174), Delhi (151), Uttar Pradesh (137) and Kerala (92). Together, these five states accounted for 66.4 per cent of all such cases recorded in the country.

“The recent cybercrime trends revealed by NCRB once again underscore why children’s safety in the online space must remain a national priority. In today’s hyperconnected world shaped increasingly by algorithms and AI (artificial intelligence), protecting children online is no longer just about controlling screens,” said Soha Moitra, Director of Programmes at CRY – Child Rights and You.

Banking fraud allegations against ADAG require thorough probe: SC

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday said the matter concerning alleged large-scale banking fraud involving Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group and its firms required a “thorough investigation” after the CBI said the total loss estimated in seven cases was around Rs 27,337 crore.

The CBI told the apex court nine FIRs had been lodged, including the two in which charge sheets have been filed, and investigations were on in seven cases.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joy-malya Bagchi was hearing a PIL filed by former bureaucrat E A S Sarma who has sought a court-monitored probe into



the alleged loan frauds exceeding Rs 40,000 crore by the Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group (ADAG) firms led by industrialist Anil Ambani.

Advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the petitioner, said it was “puzzling” that both the CBI and the Enforcement Directorate (ED) have said it was a Rs 27,000-crore scam and Anil Ambani was its “kingpin”, but they have not arrested him so far.

“Everywhere, the CBI and the ED are saying that in this Rs 27,000-crore scam, Anil Ambani is the kingpin. Yet I find it very puzzling that neither the CBI nor the ED is willing to arrest him as if he is a holy cow,” Bhushan said.

The bench observed that the apex court has repeatedly said that it would be extremely shy in directing arrest unless the investigating agency wants.

It said rather than sensationalising the investigation, the focus should be on the probe and the collection of relevant materials. The bench observed that the need for custodial interrogation in a case has to be left to the discretion of the probe agency.

Nashik TCS case accused Nida Khan arrested

NASHIK: Nida Khan, an absconding TCS employee accused in a case of alleged religious conversion and sexual harassment at the company’s Nashik unit, was arrested in central Maharashtra’s Chhattrapati Sambhajnagar, with police claiming that a local AIMIM corporator had provided her shelter.

Following her arrest on Thursday, she was produced before the Nashik Road sessions court on Friday. The court remanded her in police custody till May 11.

After her name figured in a First Information Report registered at Deolali Camp police station, Khan (27) had moved the sessions court last month seeking anticipatory bail, pleading innocence and citing her three months pregnancy. Rejecting the plea on May 2, the court had said

INSIGHT	custody till May 11
» Nashik Road sessions court on Friday remanded her in police	» Police claimed that a local AIMIM corporator had provided her shelter

there seemed to be a “systematic plan” of brainwashing the victim.

Khan was produced before Additional Sessions Judge K G Joshi on Friday with the police seeking her custody for seven days. District Government Prosecutor A S Misar said there was an attempt to convert one of the victims who was given a burqa and given training for offering Namaz.

Khan had visited the victim’s house and engaged in “activities related to Namaz and burqa,” the prosecution claimed.

A detailed probe was being conducted into Instagram, You-

Tube links and reels that were repeatedly sent to the victim, said Misar.

As per the probe, the victim’s name was to be changed to ‘Haniya’ and she was to be sent to Malaysia. Links to an alleged conversion racket at Malegaon in Nashik district also surfaced during the investigation, the prosecution said, adding that all these aspects needed a thorough probe and Khan’s custodial interrogation.

Earlier, talking about Khan’s arrest, Nashik Police Commissioner Sandeep Karnik said that a crime branch team from Chha-

trapati Sambhajnagar, led by the city’s police chief Pravin Pawar, had been tracking her movements for the past few days.

A Special Investigation Team (SIT) of the Nashik police is probing nine cases of allegedly molestation and harassment at TCS’s local unit. It had earlier arrested eight persons, including a woman operations manager, by registering nine FIRs after allegations of exploitation, attempt of forceful conversion to Islam, hurting religious sentiments, molestation and mental harassment of women employees surfaced.

Nida Khan was accused of targeting employees in a WhatsApp group, pressuring them to pray and eat non-vegetarian food. She allegedly advised women employees to dress and behave in accordance with Islamic traditions.

GamezKraft founders held in money laundering case



NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI/BENGALURU: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Friday arrested Gamez-Kraft Technologies founders Deepak Singh, Prithvi Raj Singh and Vikas Taneja in connection with a money laundering probe linked to online gaming platforms, including RummyCulture and RummyTime.

The arrests were made under Section 19 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). Deepak Singh and Prithvi Raj Singh were arrested from the National Capital Region and produced before a court for transit remand to Bengaluru, while Vikas Taneja was arrested and presented before a court in Bengaluru.

The action followed searches conducted by the ED on Thursday at 17 locations across Karnataka and the NCR linked to the company, its founders and employees. During the raids, officials seized documents, digital records and other materials considered relevant to the investigation.

According to the ED, the probe was initiated on the basis of multiple FIRs filed against the company and its founders over alleged financial irregularities and illegal online gaming operations. Some of the complaints are reportedly linked to incidents of suicide allegedly involving users of the gaming applications.

Officials said the investigation is focused on suspected generation and concealment of proceeds of crime through online paid gaming services. Authorities are examining financial transactions, corporate structures and fund flows to determine possible violations under anti-money laundering laws.

Saini releases Rs 2,115 cr to 58 lakh beneficiaries under welfare schemes

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Friday digitally transferred more than Rs 2,115 crore into the bank accounts of over 58 lakh beneficiaries under various welfare schemes through the Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) system.

The amount included the seventh installment of the Deen Dayal Lado Lakshmi Yojana, subsidy under the Har Ghar-Har Grihini scheme, compensation for Kharif crop damage in 2025, payments under the Bhavantar Bharpai Yojana and social security pensions.

Addressing reporters, Saini said Rs 205 crore was transferred to 9.76 lakh women beneficiaries under the seventh installment of

the Deen Dayal Lado Lakshmi Yojana. He said a total of Rs 1,415 crore has so far been released under the scheme.

The chief minister said over Rs 1,146 crore was credited to more than 35 lakh beneficiaries under 18 social security pension schemes, including old-age pension and pensions for Divyangjan beneficiaries.

Saini also released Rs 370 crore as compensation to over 1.5 lakh farmers whose Kharif crops were damaged due to rain and waterlogging. Besides this, Rs 100 crore post-matric scholarship was transferred to more than 64,000 Scheduled Caste students from Class 11 to postgraduate level.

He said Haryana was ensuring transparent delivery of welfare

schemes through digital governance and the Parivar Pehchan Patra database, enabling eligible beneficiaries to receive benefits without visiting government offices. The chief minister also launched the digital platform of the Haryana Online Building Plan Approval System, which will allow citizens to obtain approvals related to plots and construction online.

Meanwhile, targeting the AAP government in Punjab, Saini alleged that the neighbouring state was facing a worsening law-and-order situation, drug menace and illegal mining. He claimed that people in Punjab were losing faith in the AAP government and looking towards Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the BJP for political change and stability.

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Friday said the state was witnessing a “historic and revolutionary transformation” under the AAP government, with canal water reaching tail-end villages for the first time and uninterrupted daytime power supply now being ensured for farmers.

Addressing gatherings during the ‘Shukrana Yatra’ at Mansa and Sardulgarh, Mann said the government was working with honesty and transparency to safeguard farmers’ interests, maintain communal harmony and ensure strict punishment for those involved in sacrilege incidents.



Highlighting the recently enacted Jaagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar Amendment Act, 2026, the chief minister said the law provides life imprisonment for those found guilty of sacrilege and strict punishment, including penalties up to Rs 50 lakh, for those protecting or aiding the accused. He alleged that lead-

ers of the Akali Dal and Congress had approached the High Court seeking cancellation of the legislation as they feared action under the law.

Mann said sacrilege incidents were part of a conspiracy to disturb peace and brotherhood in Punjab and asserted that no accused would now escape punishment by citing mental illness or other excuses.

The chief minister also highlighted irrigation reforms, saying canal water utilisation for irrigation had risen from 21 per cent in 2022 to nearly 68 per cent. He said around 14,000 km of pipelines and watercourses had been laid or revived to ensure water reached remote villages and tail-end areas.

Somnath: Symbol of a thousand years of faith

NAYAB SINGH SAINI

Indian society makes a remarkable confluence of our ancient civilization and culture. Our country is home to many revered sites that strengthen our faith and cement our cultural identity. The Somnath Temple in Gujarat is not merely a place of worship, it is a living symbol of India’s spiritual resolve. Ranking first among the twelve Jyotirlingas of Lord Shiva, the Somnath Temple occupies a unique position in India’s sacred geography.

The reality is that the image of the Somnath Temple is inextricably woven into the very existence of every Indian. It is a moment of pride that I am sharing my thoughts today on the Somnath Temple. Under the leadership of the Narendra Modi government at the Centre, the Haryana Government is lending its undiluted support to this sacred endeavour. The Government of India is observing the period from May 8 to 11 as the Somnath Swabhimana Parv, a celebration marking 1,000 years since the first attack on the Somnath Temple, and as a testament to the temple’s eternal and indestructible nature. This temple has a unique history of attacks and reconstruction over centuries. After the attack in 1026, it was rebuilt which bears testimony to Indian society’s unshakeable faith and cultural consciousness.

After Independence, the temple was reconstructed through the efforts made by Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, and on May 11, 1951, its consecration ceremony



was performed. The very purpose of celebrating this festival is to affirm that no matter how many upheavals come, Somnath was and will remain a symbol of our unwavering faith. It resides in the hearts of all Indians. This festival is also an occasion to remember the countless number of great souls who stood up to defend the temple from repeated attacks with unflinching resolve.

In the 1940s, the cry for indepen-

dence filled the air across India and, under the leadership of great leaders like Sardar Patel, the foundations of a free India were being laid. But the sorry state of the Somnath Temple deeply troubled him. On November 13, 1947, during the Diwali celebrations, Sardar Patel stood before the crumbling ruins of Somnath, took seawater in his hands, and made this solemn vow: “On this (Gujarati) New Year, it is our resolve that Somnath shall be rebuilt. The people of Saurashtra will have to contribute in a big way. This is a sacred task in which everyone must play a part.”

His call echoed not only across Gujarat but the entire country, and attracted enthusiastic and overwhelming response. Sadly, Sardar Patel could not live to see his dream fulfilled. Before the restored Somnath Temple could open its doors to devotees, he bid farewell to this world.

Our Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has expressed his deep reverence for Somnath on this sacred occasion. For more than 75 years, this temple has emerged as a powerful centre of India’s cultural self-confidence and unbreakable faith. Shri Modi Ji, who is also Chairman of the Shree Somnath Trust, has taken the resolve to preserve this heritage and pass it on to the future generations.

Today, the Somnath Temple stands as an unparalleled confluence of grand architecture, spiritual energy, and cultural heritage. It is not merely a temple, but a living pilgrimage site connected to the very soul of the nation, attracting

millions of devotees every day. Modern amenities are being expanded on the Somnath Temple complex, better arrangements have been made for the pilgrims, and cultural activities are being stepped up, making this sacred site not only a centre of faith, but also a prominent destination for tourism and cultural enrichment.

PM Modi has given Hinduism a bold and prominent representation by bringing religious and pilgrimage sites across the country to international renown. Inspired by his guiding principle of “Development as well as Heritage,” he has equipped spiritual centres, from Somnath to Kashi, Kamakhya to Kedarnath, Ayodhya to Ujjain, with modern facilities, while also preserving their traditional identity. The visible impact of this is that devotees from across India and abroad, including the younger generation, are flocking to these religious sites. Decidedly, PM Modi’s leadership has revitalised Hinduism, inspiring Indians around the world to return to their roots and rediscover the significance of their faith.

The love for the nation that PM Modi embodies keeps inspiring one and all. He maintains that visiting Somnath will give one the experience of that unconquered spirit which, despite every assault, kept its identity and culture intact. I am confident that the mere sight of this extraordinary spiritual force will leave one with an unforgettable experience. (The author is the Chief Minister of Haryana)

Nation Briefs

ECR REVISES TIMINGS OF ANAND VIHAR- BOUND SPECIAL TRAINS

NEW DELHI: The East Central Railway has revised the timetable of special trains running between Saharsa, Purnea Court and Anand Vihar. Under the revised schedule, passengers travelling on the Purnea Court-Anand Vihar Special (05579/05580) will now reach Anand Vihar in 30 hours instead of 32:30 hours. Similarly, the Saharsa-Anand Vihar Special (05575/05576) will complete the journey in 28 hours instead of 29 hours. The revised timings for the Purnea Court-Anand Vihar Special will come into effect from May 15, while the new schedule for the Saharsa-Anand Vihar Special will be implemented from May 19. Train number 05579 from Purnea Court will depart at 7 pm instead of 4.30 pm, while train number 05575 from Saharsa will leave at 8 pm instead of 9 pm.

NFR: RPF DETECTS NARCOTICS WORTH RS 2.35 CR IN APRIL

MALIGAON: The Railway Protection Force (RPF) of Northeast Frontier Railway registered 3,081 cases under various sections of the Railways Act in April and prosecuted over 3,000 offenders for unlawful activities on railway premises. During ticket checking drives, the RPF helped detect 1,074 ticketless travellers and recovered fines exceeding Rs 10 lakh. The force also detected 33 narcotics smuggling cases worth over Rs 2.35 crore and arrested 15 people in illicit liquor smuggling cases. In anti-touting operations, four touts were arrested and 47 railway tickets worth Rs 1.43 lakh were seized.



EDITORIAL
CRISIS OF
PUBLIC TRUST

For years, India's banking scandals have followed a familiar script. Public money disappears into opaque corporate structures, banks quietly absorb massive losses, investigative agencies move at a glacial pace, and the public is left with little more than headlines filled with staggering numbers. Eventually, outrage fades, accountability becomes selective, and institutional memory weakens. That is why the Supreme Court's recent observation in the alleged banking fraud cases linked to the Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group matters beyond the individual controversy itself. When the court says the matter requires a "thorough investigation" and stresses the need for public confidence in the probe, it is acknowledging a deeper national anxiety: whether India's financial system is truly capable of holding powerful corporate actors accountable in a transparent and timely manner.

The figures involved are not minor accounting irregularities. The Central Bureau of Investigation has informed the court that seven ongoing cases involve estimated losses of around Rs 27,337 crore, while allegations across the broader controversy stretch even higher. Multiple FIRs, thousands of documents, dozens of lookout circulars, and allegations of diversion of public funds have now become part of the public record. Yet what has unsettled many observers is not merely the scale of the alleged fraud, but the perception of uneven enforcement. Senior advocate Prashant Bhushan's provocative question before the court — why no arrest has taken place if agencies themselves describe Anil Ambani as the "kingpin" — reflects a larger frustration that often surrounds white-collar crime investigations in India. The public has repeatedly witnessed ordinary borrowers face swift coercive action for defaults worth lakhs, while large corporate disputes involving thousands of crores move through years of procedural complexity. The perception may not always reflect the legal realities of investigation, but perceptions themselves shape public trust in institutions.

At the same time, the Supreme Court's caution against turning investigative agencies into "bloodhounds" deserves equal attention. India's legal system cannot selectively abandon due process simply because a case involves a high-profile industrialist. The court is right to remind the country that custodial interrogation is not a spectacle to satisfy public anger, but a legal decision that must remain within the discretion of investigating agencies. Recent jurisprudence, including the principles laid down in cases such as Pankaj Bansal v. Union of India, has increasingly emphasised procedural fairness, especially in economic offences. The temptation to equate arrest with justice is dangerous. Democracies are not strengthened when investigation becomes theatre. They are strengthened when investigations are credible, evidence-driven, insulated from political pressure, and capable of surviving judicial scrutiny. The real challenge, therefore, is not whether a particular individual is arrested immediately, but whether the investigative process ultimately uncovers the full truth without fear or favour.

Yet India cannot ignore the systemic dimensions of these recurring banking crises. Behind every large corporate default lies a chain of institutional failures extending far beyond one businessman or one company. Public sector banks have repeatedly been accused of weak due diligence, politically influenced lending, excessive restructuring, and delayed recognition of stress. The era between 2008 and 2017 saw Indian banks aggressively lend to infrastructure, telecom, and power sectors under the assumption that rapid economic growth would continue indefinitely. When projects stalled, global markets weakened, and debt burdens ballooned, the banking system was left exposed. The subsequent explosion of non-performing assets was not created overnight; it emerged from a culture in which risk was poorly assessed and accountability within lending institutions often remained diffuse. In many cases, investigations begin only after collapse becomes unavoidable. By then, losses are socialised while the financial pain is ultimately borne by taxpayers, depositors, and the broader economy. That is why every major banking fraud case should force India to ask uncomfortable questions not only about corporate conduct, but also about regulatory vigilance, audit quality, and the functioning of public financial institutions themselves.

There is also a broader economic consequence that extends beyond the courtroom. Investor confidence depends not merely on ease of doing business, but on the certainty that rules apply equally to all. India seeks to project itself as a stable global investment destination, a manufacturing hub, and an emerging financial power. That ambition requires institutions capable of dealing decisively with economic misconduct without collapsing into either political vendetta or institutional paralysis. Endless investigations that produce little closure damage credibility just as much as arbitrary enforcement does. The Supreme Court's decision to monitor the probe, while leaving operational discretion with investigative agencies, attempts to strike that difficult balance. Ultimately, the country does not need sensationalism; it needs clarity. If wrongdoing occurred, accountability must follow through evidence and law. If allegations are exaggerated or unsupported, that too must

QUIET
REVOLT



SANDIP BANERJEE

THE WRITER IS AN
EDUCATOR FROM
KOLKATA

The purpose of education is not to produce obedient citizens or efficient workers. It is to help every human being become fully, gloriously, fearlessly alive

Tagore's Revolution of the Mind

From Santiniketan's open-air classrooms to his critique of colonial education, Rabindranath Tagore envisioned learning as liberation long before holistic education gained global recognition

In the red dust of Santiniketan, beneath a canopy of ancient mango trees, a school began in 1901 with five children and one impossible dream: that education could set the human soul free rather than chain it. The man who planted that dream was Rabindranath Tagore—poet, philosopher, painter, composer, rebel, and, above all, one of the greatest social educators the modern world has ever known.

He was born in 1861 into the dazzling brilliance of Jorasanko Thakur Bari in Calcutta, the youngest son of Debendranath Tagore, the Maharshi of the Brahmo Samaj. From the age of five, he was dragged through a succession of schools—Oriental Seminary, Normal School, Bengal Academy. By the time he was twelve, Rabindranath had quietly declared war on the entire system. He simply stopped going. Instead, he wandered the ghats, listened to boatmen sing Bhatiyali on the Ganges, watched potters at work, and learned Sanskrit from pandits in the courtyard. That early rebellion never left him. It became the foundation of everything he would later build.

In 1901, at the age of 40, he arrived at the barren land of Santiniketan with his wife, Mrinalini (who would die only a year later), and their children. He had almost no money, but he had a vision so clear it hurt. On December 22, he began classes under the open sky. There were no walls, no blackboards, no bells, no punishments. Children learned botany by planting saplings, history by listening to wandering Baul singers, and geography by walking across the khoai ravines when the rain carved new rivers overnight. This is what modern education has categorically termed "holistic education". Much before such nomenclature was coined, Tagore could make out that, to achieve learning outcomes, one must learn to connect education with natural surroundings and practical application.

Utilising the prize money from the Nobel Prize, Tagore bought more land, built simple hostels of mud and thatch, and invited the world to come and teach. Scientists from England, dancers from Java, painters from Japan, scholars from China—all came. In 1921, he turned the school into Visva-Bharati, a university where the world itself would be the campus. Albert Einstein met Tagore in 1930. Together, they discussed objective truth versus human truth. Tagore, however, emphasised universal human



Tagore transformed Santiniketan into a radical experiment where art, nature, freedom and humanity shaped learning

consciousness that reconciles individual perception with objective reality. This had always been Tagore's philosophy. His views on education and social order also rested on this principle. Here lies his perpetual relevance, because he believed in the religion of man, the greatest religion of any enlightened mind. Illumined minds like Okakura Kakuzō came from Japan; Mahatma Gandhi and an entire constellation of Indian luminaries came here. Students from the Western world became students at Visva-Bharati. A living bridge between East and West was rising in the middle of rural Bengal.

Tagore believed that the highest education is that which makes our life harmonious with all existence. Like Plato and Aristotle, he encouraged people to question, to unravel the reason behind all happenings. He despised the colonial education system that turned bright children into pale clerks with bent spines and frightened eyes. At Santiniketan, the day began with music, moved through gardening and craft, included wrestling and swimming in the Kopai River, and ended with meditation at sunset. Seasons dictated the timetable, not the clock. Everyone went out to paint when nature decked itself in colour. Examinations were not paramount because, Tagore said, "a lamp cannot be lighted by being repeatedly weighed on scales." Children learned in their mother tongue, danced before they could read, and were never, ever compared with one another. Today,

the National Education Policy speaks of peer learning and of primary education, where examinations are not considered paramount. Tagore had realised long ago that marks came secondary; learning through practice counted primary. Today's education pundits are merely endorsing what Tagore implemented more than a century ago.

He extended the same spirit to rural reconstruction. In 1922, he started Sriniketan next door, an institute for village upliftment. With the young Englishman Leonard Elmhirst (who would later found Dartington Hall in Devon), Tagore fought moneylenders, dug wells, introduced scientific farming, revived dying crafts, and set up health cooperatives. When floods devastated his own Patisar estate, he sold his personal manuscripts to feed the victims. He walked barefoot through villages singing with Bauls, slept on mud floors, and told peasants that the same divine spark that burned in him burned in them too.

Long before the world spoke of globalisation, Tagore warned against the poison of aggressive nationalism. As early as 1908, he walked away from the Swadeshi movement when it turned violent. During the First World War, he wrote three scorching essays on nationalism that remain among the most prophetic political documents ever written. He called the modern nation-state "a terrible absurdity" and predicted that the worship of power would devour humanity. In 1919, after the Jallianwala

Bagh massacre, he returned his knight-hood with a letter so dignified and devastating that even the British Empire felt ashamed. Yet he was equally ruthless with Indian orthodoxy. His stories tore apart caste, widow oppression, and superstition. In Gora, he exposed the hollowness of both blind tradition and blind westernisation. He gave us some of the strongest, most complex women in world literature at a time when most Indian women were not even allowed to read.

At the heart of everything lay a simple but revolutionary faith: every human being carries the infinite within. "I have within me a divine essence which is ever creating, ever uniting, ever fulfilling itself in joy," he wrote in Sadhana. That is why art was never extracurricular at Santiniketan—it was the soul's native language. Children painted before they could write properly, composed songs before they knew notation, and danced under the stars because rhythm, Tagore said, is the deepest law of the universe.

Eighty-five years after his death, the world is finally catching up with him. Children are burning out in coaching factories; forests are disappearing; nations are building walls again; mental health is collapsing under the weight of comparison and competition. And in the middle of all this madness, Tagore's voice comes back across the century, gentle but unbreakable:

"Let your life dance lightly on the edges of Time like dew on the tip of a leaf"

We need him now more than we ever did. We need schools where children plant trees and sing before they are ranked. We need villages where dignity matters more than GDP. We need a world that remembers the earth is not a resource but a mother, and that every child, no matter how poor, carries a fragment of the divine. That was Rabindranath Tagore's lifelong teaching, and it is still the most dangerous, most beautiful idea humanity has ever been offered: the purpose of education is not to produce obedient citizens or efficient workers. It is to help every human being become fully, gloriously, fearlessly alive. Until we learn that lesson, the red soil of Santiniketan will keep waiting, patient as ever, under the same mango trees that once sheltered a dreamer who refused to let the world cage its children.

Views expressed are personal

AT
VANTAGE



SHUTAPA PAUL

THE WRITER
IS AN AUTHOR
AND MEDIA
ENTREPRENEUR

India is driving ahead with near-pure ethanol fuel in vehicles, even as the environmental impact requires a cautious review

A Questionable Blend

As India accelerates towards higher ethanol blending targets, concerns over groundwater depletion, food security, crop sustainability and ecological balance are intensifying

India's push to blend ethanol with petrol has triggered a debate of contradictions. Even as we aim for enhanced energy security, are we prepared to have it at the cost of water scarcity? The argument unleashed by those in favour and those opposed surely places us between a rock and a hard place, urging for deeper analysis before final decisions are taken. When the nation's future of food, water, and energy hangs in the balance, a cautious review is not just expected but should be mandatory.

The rumblings started last year when auto enthusiasts warned of ethanol-blended petrol ruining cars. As the government pushes now moves from E20 (or 20 per cent ethanol blended petrol) and E25 (25 per cent ethanol) to goals of E85 (85 per cent ethanol) and E100 (completely ethanol fuel), there's more than just the car's health to worry about. While Flex Fuel Vehicles (FFV) are touted to tackle the new fuel, the bigger concern is the impact of the "green fuel" created on food and water. Policy decisions are not knee-jerk reactions that we take in haste and regret at leisure. Rightly so, the government has invited public comments till May 28 before amending the Central Motor Vehicles Rules that will officially recognise E85 and E100 as automotive fuels.

The spanner in the works had already come — the inter-ministerial Expert Group, comprising technical and industry experts, and constituted by the government under the NITI Aayog, had raised the alarm bells long ago. In its report titled — Roadmap for ethanol blending in India 2020-2025' — submitted on June 5, 2021, had canvassed for a phased roll-out and scale-up plan. It also highlighted a drop in fuel efficiency to the tune of 6-7 per cent for four-wheelers and 3-4 per cent for two-wheelers designed for E0 and calibrated for E10, while 1-2 per cent for four-wheelers planned for E10 and adjusted for E20. The report also clearly warned about water consumption and agricultural sustainability in a nation that's already straddling the issue of rapid groundwater depletion. The group urged a change in crop patterns while encouraging low water consumption food crops, such as maize (that can be rain-fed), and 2G (second-generation) feedstock (i.e. non-



As the government pushes now moves from E20 and E25 to goals of E85 and E100, there's more than just the car's health to worry about

food biomass or agricultural waste such as rice/wheat straw, sugarcane bagasse, wood chips, and so on). They concluded that sugar remained "the most lucrative food crop for ethanol, even though it has the highest water consumption per acre. Amongst grains, maize is the least water-intensive crop for ethanol production, although the litre of ethanol generated per acre is lower than that of rice and broken rice. We must continue to explore the feasibility of other grains which can supplement sugar in ethanol production to meet the 2025 targets".

Even though we are well ahead of the set timelines, there's been a sudden, inexplicable speed of movement. No doubt that the fuel shift would provide a massive boost to ethanol and its allied sectors, but the apparent environmental damage cannot be overlooked. 10,000 litres of water are used to produce a litre of ethanol — you may have read this worrying statistic doing the rounds. Ethanol is mainly produced by the water-guzzling crop — rice. Maize and sugarcane can also be used, but rice, which has long been a sustainability concern, is the primary source of ethanol production. The argument is also that if farmers are incentivised to produce high water-consuming crops such as rice, they won't readily switch to more eco-friendly ones. Another underlying worry is the government's decision to divert 90 lakh tonnes of rice for ethanol production by reducing broken rice distributed through the Public Distribution System

(PDS) from 25 per cent to 10 per cent. The government claims that this will still improve the quality of grain received through PDS as whole-grain FCI (Food Corporation of India) rice will not be given to distilleries; critics, though, have flagged the move for purportedly being anti-poor and reducing food support to marginalised sections of society. Simultaneously, devoting excessive amounts of food grain towards ethanol production can lead to food shortages and skyrocketing food prices.

India is not the first one in the race for ethanol adoption. Brazil has mandatory use of E27, and is the only country in the world to use E100. The US is using E10, E15, and E85. Several EU nations, such as the UK, France, Belgium, Germany, and Finland, have E10; so do Canada and Thailand. And while these are global successes, except Brazil, no other nation has yet used E100. Also, no other nation is as water-stressed as India, where several metropolitan cities may run dry by 2030. NITI Aayog's Composite Water Management Index (CWMI) has warned that Delhi, Bengaluru, Chennai, along with 18 others, are heading towards 'Day Zero'. This increasingly uncertain world demands that every nation become more self-contained and self-reliant. However, every country is facing different ecological challenges and climate crises. We owe it to our next generation to chew the cud on every far-reaching policy decision.

Views expressed are personal

WHO SAID
WHAT



M.K.Stalin
@mkstalin

The results of the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly elections have been announced, and the Election Commission has released the list of Members of the Legislative Assembly elected by the people. The existing Legislative Assembly has already been dissolved, and His Excellency the Governor has issued the proclamation to that effect. In such a situation, it is not only the compulsion of the times but also the most important duty of democracy that a new government must be formed for the elected Members of the Legislative Assembly to take their oaths of office and to advance the welfare of the state! In this context, on behalf of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam, I request that His Excellency the Governor take immediate action to form a new administration in accordance with the Constitution, in order to avoid any delay in the formation of the government.

IRAN WAR CAUSES A GLOBAL SPIKE IN FUEL PRICES

UAE reports drone, missile attack after US says traded fire with Iran

DUBAI: The United Arab Emirates said it responded to another Iranian missile barrage on Friday, hours after the US said it traded fire with Iranian forces in the Strait of Hormuz, in the latest blows to a shaky month-old ceasefire.

The UAE's Defence Ministry said three people were wounded after air defences "engaged" two ballistic missiles and three drones launched by Iran. It was not clear if all were successfully intercepted. Authorities told people to stay away from any fallen debris.

The US said it thwarted attacks on three Navy ships and struck Iranian military facilities in the strait.

Iran has mostly blocked the critical waterway for global



People walk as Burj Khalifa, the world's tallest building, being illuminated with the UAE national flag colors Dubai AP/FILE PHOTO

energy since the U.S. and Israel launched the war on February 28, causing a global spike in fuel prices and rattling world markets.

US President Donald Trump played down the exchange of fire on Thursday, calling the US strikes a "love tap" in a phone call

Highlights

- » The UAE's Defence Ministry said three people were wounded
- » It was not clear if all drones were successfully intercepted
- » Iranian state media said the country's forces exchanged fire with 'the enemy' on Qeshm Island in strait

with ABC. But he reiterated threats to resume full-scale bombing if Iran doesn't accept an agreement to reopen the strait and roll back its nuclear programme.

Iran's Foreign Ministry said the US strikes were a "clear violation" of the ceasefire. Tehran had previously said it was examining the latest US proposals for ending the war delivered via Pakistan, which is mediating.

The US military said it had intercepted Iranian attacks on three Navy ships in the Strait of Hormuz late Thursday and "targeted Iranian military facilities responsible for attacking US forces".

The US military said none of its ships were hit. Iranian state media said the country's forces exchanged fire with "the enemy" on Qeshm Island in the strait. It also reported loud noises and continuous defensive fire in western Tehran late Thursday.

AGENCIES

Italy tells Rubio that Europe needs America & vice versa

America's top diplomat Rubio wrapped up two days of fence-mending talks in Italy and the Vatican

ROME: Italian Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani said he told US Secretary of State Marco Rubio on Friday that Europe needs the United States, and vice versa, as America's top diplomat wrapped up two days of fence-mending talks in Italy and the Vatican following weeks of tensions over the US-Israeli war in Iran.

Tajani reaffirmed strong trans-Atlantic ties and said he hoped "tensions have been calmed" with Rubio's visit. He said the two discussed the Iran war and spillover into Lebanon, as well as the situation in Venezuela and Cuba. The US secretary of state also met Friday with Premier Giorgia Meloni.

"I believe things can go in the right direction," Tajani said. "I am convinced Europe needs America — Italy needs America — and the United States also needs Europe and Italy."

President Donald Trump's tariffs, his complaints about Europe's unwillingness to help the US with the Iran war and his attacks on Pope Leo XIV have fueled weeks of sharp disagreements over trade and defence cooperation between the two traditionally strong allies.

Tajani reaffirmed Friday that Italy stood ready to send in its navy to help demine the Strait of Hormuz once a permanent ceasefire is reached with Iran, and to maintain its already strong presence in Lebanon with the UN peace-



US Secretary of State Marco Rubio with Italian Premier Giorgia Meloni

“ITALY STOOD READY TO SEND IN ITS NAVY TO HELP DEMINE THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ ONCE A PERMANENT CEASEFIRE IS REACHED WITH IRAN”

The State Department, for its part, said Rubio raised efforts to "promote freedom of navigation and maritime security," as well as a need for an end to the war in Ukraine, and for Western nations to protect their economic interests.

Trump has criticised both the Pope and Italy's government for opposing the Iran war. Meloni has called the US-Israeli bombing "illegal" and rebuked Trump's remarks about the pontiff as "unacceptable."

Trump has responded by accusing Meloni of lacking courage and being "negative" on helping the US with the war.

AGENCIES

keeping mission. He said he told Rubio that Italy considers the presence of US troops in Europe to reinforce NATO important, a reference to Trump's threats to pull back America's troops.

Bomb explodes at Dutch premier's party headquarters, but none injured

THE HAGUE: A bomb that was pushed through a letter slot exploded at the party headquarters of Dutch Prime Minister Rob Jetten but didn't injure anyone, and the centrist leader vowed Friday not to be intimidated by the attack.

Police said they had arrested a 37-year-old suspect in the bombing late Thursday at the headquarters

of the centrist D66 party in The Hague, but declined to release any further details including any suspected motive.

Jetten, who took office in February, told reporters during his weekly news conference that it was "pretty futile if you think you can intimidate politicians with these kinds of actions."

AGENCIES

Israeli strikes kill 5 in Lebanon

BEIRUT: Israeli airstrikes on southern Lebanon killed at least five people Friday, while Hezbollah fired rockets on northern Israel without inflicting any casualties.

The Health Ministry in Lebanon said that an Israeli airstrike on the southern village of Toura near the port city of Tyre killed four people and wounded eight. Lebanon's state-run National News Agency reported another airstrike near the southeastern village of Kfar Chouba. The strikes came hours after the

In the early afternoon, Hezbollah fired a salvo of rockets toward north Israel

Israeli army's Arabic-language spokesperson issued an evacuation warning to the residents of six villages in Tyre province, including Toura.

In the early afternoon, Hezbollah fired a salvo of rockets toward northern Israel.

The Israeli military said it shot down one rocket while the rest fell in open areas without inflicting casualties. The latest exchange between Israel and Hezbollah, despite a ceasefire that has been in place since April 17, came two days after the first Israeli airstrike on Beirut's southern suburbs since the ceasefire went into effect.

The Israeli military said Thursday it had killed Ahmed Balout, who it identified as a commander in Hezbollah's elite Radwan Force, along with two other militants.

AGENCIES

ASEAN leaders adopt crisis plan to mitigate backlash from Mideast war

CEBU: Southeast Asian leaders adopted a contingency plan Friday to mitigate the impact of the Iran war on their people and economies but acknowledged it will be difficult to enforce complex steps like establishing a regional fuel reserve to ensure a steady supply.

The Philippines, among the worst affected by fuel price spikes caused by the Iran war, hosted the group's annual summit on the central island province of Cebu.

President Ferdinand Marcos Jr. ordered the summit stripped of the traditional pomp and pageantry in keeping with the economic headwinds worldwide.

ASEAN's contingency plan calls for actions including the ratification possibly this year of an agreement that will pave the way for coordinated emergency fuel sharing, planning a regional power grid and fuel stockpile and diversifying the region's sources of crude oil.

Promoting the use of electric vehicles and study-



Successful conclusion of the 48th ASEAN Summit

ing the use of new technologies, including civilian nuclear energy, were also part of the crisis plan.

The contingency steps will be implemented immediately but the establishment of a regional fuel stockpiled and power grid is a complex matter and may take a long time, Marcos said.

"Let's talk about the fuel reserve. Is it going to be in one single place? Is it going to be

scattered through the whole of ASEAN?" he asked.

A regional power grid that allows countries to trade electricity has been considered for years but has only been realized "at a fairly small level," Marcos said, but added the leaders were unfazed.

"They are committed to making this succeed because everyone is suffering and everyone wants to get out of this situation," he said.

AGENCIES

Pentagon begins releasing new files on UFOs

WASHINGTON: The Pentagon has begun releasing new files on UFOs, saying members of the public can draw their own conclusions on "unidentified anomalous phenomena."

Besides the Pentagon, the effort is led by the White House, the director of national intelligence, the Energy Department, NASA and the FBI.

The Pentagon said Friday in a post on X that while past administrations sought to discredit or dissuade the American people, President Donald Trump "is focused on providing maximum transparency to the public, who can ultimately make up their own minds about the information contained in these files."

The Pentagon says additional documents will be released on a rolling basis.

Trump, a Republican, has been teasing the announcement since February.

AGENCIES

UK PM takes responsibility for local election losses

LONDON: British Prime Minister Keir Starmer on Friday said he takes responsibility for the "very tough" losses for the Labour Party in the local election, which threw up big wins for the anti-immigration Reform UK.

Speaking to reporters as the vote count for Thursday's UK-wide polls for local councils and devolved Scottish and Welsh parliaments continues, Starmer said the outcome would not weaken his resolve to carry on tackling the challenges facing the country's economy.

He is faced with calls to quit as party leader and prime minister after Labour lost its majorities in several key councils of Westminster, Southampton, Exeter, Redditch, Wandsworth, Hartlepool, Tamworth and Tameside.

"The results are tough, these are people who put so much into their communities, so much into our party.

And that hurts, and it should hurt, and I take responsibility.

"I'm not going to walk away and plunge the country into chaos," he said.

Asked if he would be the one leading the Labour Party into the next general election, expected in 2029, he replied: "Yes. It was a five-year term I was elected to do, I intend to see that through."

AGENCIES



UK PM Keir Starmer

Key Point

- » The loss threw up big wins for the anti-immigration Reform UK
- » 'I'm not going to walk away and plunge the country into chaos'

they are very tough, and there's no sugarcoating it," said Starmer.

"We have lost brilliant Labour representatives across the country,

UK health chiefs track all cruise passengers exposed to hantavirus

LONDON: The UK health authorities on Friday continue to trace all British nationals who were exposed to the dangerous rat-borne hantavirus outbreak on a cruise ship, with a third suspected case being logged.

The UK Health Security Agency (UKHSA) said two British nationals are confirmed to have the hantavirus and a third Briton is suspected to be afflicted on board the MV Hondius at the Tristan da Cunha island in the South Atlantic.

While none of the British citizens on board are reporting symptoms, they are being closely monitored and will be asked to isolate for 45 days upon returning to the UK.

"This is an evolving situation, and we are working closely with partners to support British Nationals on board the MV Hondius," said Professor Robin May, Chief Scientific Officer at UKHSA.

"The risk to the general population remains very low and the public can be reassured that established infection control measures will be put in place at every step of the journey to ensure the safe repatriation of British passengers on board," he said.

AGENCIES

At least 3 hikers killed by volcano eruption on Indonesian island

JAKARTA: An explosive eruption of Mount Dukono on a remote Indonesian island killed three hikers, authorities said Friday. About 20 climbers set out Thursday to ascend the nearly 1,355-meter (4,445-foot) volcano on the island of Halmahera, in defiance of safety restrictions, said North Halmahera police chief Erlichson Pasaribu.

They became stranded when Dukono erupted at 7:41 am local time, spewing a thick ash column that rose about 10 kilometres (6.2 miles) above the summit. The eruption was recorded on seismographs for more than 16 minutes, Indonesia's Geological Agency said.

"They were aware that climbing was prohibited as the mountain is a restricted zone due to its high alert status, but insisted on going ahead," Pasaribu said in a television interview.

Rescue teams were deployed after receiving an emergency signal from the mountain area. Three men — two Singaporean and one Indonesian national — died at the scene, Pasaribu said.

As of Friday afternoon, 14 climbers, including seven for-



Foreign nationals, had been safely evacuated.

Five of those evacuated were reported injured. Rescue teams continued to search for other climbers believed to be attempting to descend. The bodies had not yet been recovered because continued eruptions and dangerous conditions prevented rescue teams from reaching the location.

The Centre for Volcanology and Geological Hazard Mitigation has long banned activities within a 4-kilometre (2.5-mile) radius of Dukono's crater, citing hazards such as volcanic bombs, ashfall and toxic gases.

AGENCIES

AS UKRAINE WAR WEIGHS ON PUTIN

Russia holds muted World War II victory day celebrations this year

MOSCOW: Tensions are high as Russia prepares to celebrate its most important secular holiday Saturday, with fears about security amid the war with Ukraine and signs of domestic discontent casting a shadow over annual celebrations in Moscow's Red Square.

A unilateral ceasefire in Ukraine that Russia announced for Friday and Saturday quickly unravelled.

Moscow and Kyiv blamed each other for the continued fighting, just as they did when Ukraine's own unilateral ceasefire swiftly collapsed earlier in the week.

The accusations reflect the deep-seated lack of trust between the two sides more than four years after Russia's full-scale invasion of its neighbour. That has thwarted US-led diplomatic efforts to find a peace settlement.

Ukraine's new drone and missile technology has helped it hit deep inside Russia frequently and accurately in recent months, especially major oil facilities.

Meanwhile, rumblings of unhappiness with some of the Kremlin's wartime policies



Moscow and Kyiv blamed each other for the continued fighting

have put the spotlight on Russian President Vladimir Putin, who is due to make a speech on Saturday to mark Victory Day.

It commemorates victory over Nazi Germany 81 years ago in World War II and has in the past provided an opportunity for fanfare and national fervour as well as showcasing

Russia's military might. This year is different. The Russian Defence Ministry claimed Friday that its forces in Ukraine "completely ceased combat operations and remained at their previously occupied lines and positions" from midnight, when Putin's unilateral ceasefire came into force.

But it accused Ukrainian

forces of continuing to strike Russian positions as well as civilian infrastructure in border areas of the Belgorod and the Kursk regions.

Air defences shot down 390 Ukrainian drones and six Neptune long-range guided missiles aimed at Russia after midnight, according to the ministry.

AGENCIES

World Briefs

PROSECUTORS SEEK TO STRIP US CITIZENSHIP FROM CUBAN SPY

MIAMI: Federal prosecutors are seeking to revoke the US citizenship of former US Ambassador Manuel Rocha, the imprisoned former diplomat who served as a secret agent for Cuba dating back to the 1970s in one of the longest-running betrayals in the history of the foreign service. The US Attorney's Office in Miami filed a civil denaturalisation complaint Thursday that would complete the Colombian-born Rocha's fall from grace, stripping him of the citizenship he attained after moving to New York City at age 10 with his widowed mother and two siblings. Rocha, 75, was arrested in late 2023 and later sentenced to 15 years in federal prison after admitting he worked for decades as a secret agent for communist Cuba.

BULGARIA'S PARLIAMENT VOTES NEW GOVERNMENT INTO OFFICE

SOFIA: Bulgaria's parliament on Friday formally approved Rumen Radev as the new prime minister in a bid to end political instability and spur economic development in the EU member country. "We have no illusions about the crises and trials facing the government, which will soon be seeking your support — galloping prices, budget, missing reforms, a severe global energy crisis and escalating conflicts," Radev told lawmakers. The chamber voted 124-70 with 36 abstentions to elect Radev, a 62-year-old former president, as prime minister. Radev resigned from the mostly ceremonial presidency in January, a few months before the end of his second term, to launch a bid to lead the government in the more powerful role as prime minister.

Federal court strikes down Trump’s 10% global tariffs

These new tariffs were imposed by Trump on all countries, including India, on February 24 for 150 days

WASHINGTON: In another setback to the White House, a US federal court has struck down the 10 per cent global tariffs slapped by President Donald Trump, terming them “invalid” and “unauthorised by law”.

These new tariffs were imposed by Trump on all countries, including India, on February 24 for 150 days following a Supreme Court verdict that struck down his earlier sweeping levies.

The Supreme Court had said that the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) does not authorise the imposition of duties.

In a split verdict, the Court of International Trade on Thursday ruled that the provisions of the Trade Act of 1974, invoked by Trump to impose 10 per cent tariffs could be effective only in case of a balance of payment crisis.

Judges Mark A Barnett and Claire R Kelly said in the ruling that if the president has the ability to select among the sub-accounts to identify a balance-of-payments deficit, unless every sub-account is balanced, the president would always be able to identify a balance-of-payments deficit.

“Such an expansive read-



US President Donald Trump

The Court of International Trade on Thursday ruled that the provisions of the Trade Act of 1974, could be effective only in case of a balance of payment crisis

ing of the statute” would give Trump unlimited tariff power that belongs to Congress, the two judges said, adding that such preferred interpretation of the statute by the government should be disfavoured.

“This case turns on the meaning of Section 122 and whether the president asserted the existence of the conditions required by the statute in order to lawfully proclaim the import surcharges. ... As discussed further below, the

President’s Proclamation fails to assert that those required conditions have been satisfied,” the majority judges said in the ruling. Judge Timothy C Stancu disagreed with the two brother judges.

The US administration is expected to appeal against Thursday’s ruling. The court’s decision directly applied only to three of the plaintiffs, the state of Washington and two businesses, spice company Burlap & Barrel and toy company Basic Fun!

Highlights

- » The US administration is expected to appeal against Thursday’s ruling
- » Court’s decision directly applied only to three of the plaintiffs, the state of Washington & spice company Burlap & Barrel and toy company Basic Fun
- » India, US had announced framework for an interim BTA in Feb, which is now being re-negotiated in wake of Supreme Court order

Ujivan SFB Q4 profit rises 3-fold to ₹282 crore

NEW DELHI: Ujivan Small Finance Bank (SFB) on Friday reported over three-fold jump in net profit at Rs 282 crore in the fourth quarter ended March 2026.

The bank had posted a net profit of Rs 83 crore in the year-ago period.

The total income rose to Rs 2,185 crore in the January-March quarter of the financial year 2025-26 from Rs 1,843 crore in the year-ago period, Ujivan Small Finance Bank said in a regulatory filing.

The bank’s total expenditure, excluding provisions, shot up to Rs 1,670 crore from Rs 1,483 crore in the same period a year ago. On the asset quality front, the bank’s gross non-performing assets ratio marginally rose to 2.26 per cent against 2.18 per cent a year ago.

However, net NPAs, or bad loans, declined to 0.43 per cent from 0.49 per cent at the end of the fourth quarter last fiscal year. Overall provisions, excluding tax, moderated to Rs 144 crore in the quarter under review from Rs 265 crore in the same quarter a year ago.

For the entire financial year of 2025-26, Ujivan Small Finance Bank’s net profit declined 5 per cent to Rs 693 crore from Rs 726 crore in the preceding fiscal.

However, the total income rose to Rs 8,039 crore in FY26 from Rs 7,201 crore in FY25.

PFI

India seeks recognition as central hub for international aircraft finance & lease operations: Ram Mohan Naidu

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GANDHINAGAR: The Ministry of Civil Aviation, along with the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) and the Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI), on Friday organised the India Aircraft Leasing and Financing Summit 2.0 at GIFT City in Gandhinagar, Gujarat.

At the gathering, leadership was represented by Union Civil Aviation Minister Ram Mohan Naidu. In attendance, Gujarat’s chief minister, Bhupendra Patel, took part in the role of primary invitee.

Among those present were government officials, banks and key figures from air transport, meeting to explore growth at GIFT IFSC. Development of



the zone into a centre for plane leasing emerged through conversation involving long-term financing models.

One focus stood clear: building frameworks that support cross-border deals in aircraft funding. Participation

included entities with stakes in infrastructure, capital markets and fleet management strategies.

Talks unfolded around regulatory ease, tax design and access to international lenders. A shared view took

shape – not forced but gradual – about positioning the site within worldwide aviation networks. Consideration extended beyond immediate gains toward structural advantages over time.

Speaking to those present, Ram Mohan Naidu noted that India aims to become more than just a rapidly expanding aviation market; it seeks recognition as a central hub for international aircraft finance and lease operations. By 2027, the nation’s fleet of commercial planes should total around 1,100 units, rising past 2,250 within eight years after that. At this time, local airlines await delivery of 1,640 planes – this volume may generate roughly 50 billion dollars in prospects for homeworking leasing firms through the coming ten-year

period.

Despite initial challenges, progress emerged through legislative updates such as the 2025 Protection of Interests in Aircraft Objects Act.

Following that development, coordination improved via the establishment of a dedicated oversight group focused on lease frameworks.

Among the outcomes stood fresh moves in aviation finance. By March 2027, Air India intends to grow its leased fleet to 76 planes; meanwhile, IndiGo targets a rise close to 150.

In parallel, Akasa Air, together with Star Air, unveiled leasing ventures based in GIFT City. Following these steps, shifts in operational scale become evident across carriers.

Hyundai Motor India posts 22.22% decline in Q4 consolidated PAT to ₹1,255.63 crore

NEW DELHI: Hyundai Motor India Ltd on Friday reported a 22.22 per cent decline in consolidated profit after tax (PAT) to Rs 1,255.63 crore in the March quarter, impacted by higher commodity prices, unfavourable product mix and costs associated with capacity stabilisation.

The company had posted a consolidated PAT of Rs 1,614.35 crore in the corresponding period of the previous fiscal year, Hyundai Motor India Ltd (HMIL) said in a regulatory filing. Commodity headwinds and capacity stabilisation costs

dragged margins, the company said in an investor presentation. Consolidated total revenue from operations stood at Rs 18,916.15 crore, as against Rs 17,940.28 crore in the year-ago period, it added.

Total expenses were higher at Rs 17,571.66 crore as compared to Rs 15,974.46 crore in the corresponding period of the previous fiscal year, HMIL said.

Overall vehicle sales in Q4 stood at 2,08,275 units as compared to 1,91,650 units in the year-ago period, up 8.7 per cent, HMIL said in an investor presentation.

Domestic sales were up 8.5 per cent at 1,66,578 units in the fourth quarter as against 1,53,550 units in the same period a year ago. Exports were also up 9.4 per cent at 41,697 units, as compared to 38,100 units in the same period a year ago, the company said.

The company’s board has recommended a dividend of Rs 21 per equity share of face value Rs 10 each for the 2025-26 financial year. For FY26, consolidated PAT was lower at Rs 5,431.52 crore as compared to Rs 5,640.21 crore in FY25.

Consolidated total revenue

from operations in FY26 was at Rs 70,763.33 crore as compared to Rs 69,192.89 crore in FY25.

Total sales in FY26 stood at 7,75,031 units as against 7,62,052 units in FY25, the company said.

“FY26 was a year where we demonstrated our ability to navigate a challenging environment while capitalising on emerging opportunities, supported by GST 2.0 reforms, strategic product interventions, strong export volumes and our continued focus on ‘Quality of Growth,’” HMIL MD & CEO Tarun Garg said.

PFI



Income of the Jewellery Division’s India business rose 46% to Rs 17,114 crore, Titan said

This was also helped by the addition of Damas Jewellery, a UAE-based jewellery retailer, in which Titan acquired a majority stake in July last year, it added.

Income of the Jewellery Division’s India business rose 46 per cent to Rs 17,114 crore, Titan said.

Its three jewellery brands - Tanishq, Mia and Zaya - grew 48 per cent to Rs 16,047 crore.

While sales from Caratlane, a brand selling contemporary, affordable, and everyday-wear jewellery, in which Titan acquired a 98 per cent stake in 2023, recorded 22 per cent growth to Rs 1,066 crore.

Its international jewellery business grew nearly threefold to Rs 1,081 crore.

In the March quarter, the Jewellery Division added 27 stores in India, comprising 8 Tanishq stores, 14 Mia stores

and 5 Caratlane stores. Tanishq witnessed 4 new store openings in the GCC region during the quarter.

Titan’s revenue from watches and wearables rose 7.76 per cent to Rs 1,222 crore in Q4 FY26. The growth in the segment was led by analogue watches.

“The analogue segment recorded healthy double-digit growth in consumer sales, supported by good volume uptick and improvements in price realisation,” it said.

However, the volume of smart watches declined by 50 per cent in overall value, which was partially offset by an improvement in average price realisations.

Titan’s Watch business added 30 new stores in the March quarter, consisting of 17 stores in Titan World, 7 stores in Fastrack, 4 stores in its luxury retail format Helios and 2 stores in Helios Luxe.

Its eyecare segment revenue increased 17.6 per cent to Rs 227 crore. This vertical “recorded a healthy performance for the full year.”

“The growth for the quarter was led by international brands and improvement in price realisations across the product portfolio,” it said.

The eyecare is going through store optimisation, where it witnessed “37 refurbishments/ renovations, 12 new store openings and 32 closures in this period.”

Revenue from other segments, which includes its

emerging business as fragrance, wallets, and Indian dress wear (Taneria), among others, jumped 49.8 per cent to Rs 577 crore in the March quarter.

“Fragrances maintained its strong volume momentum across both the Skinn and Fastrack perfume lines, IRTW Women’s Bags witnessed robust volume growth and continued to gain in brand salience,” it said.

Sales from its ethnic wear chain, Taneara, were “flatish” for the quarter.

Titan is a joint venture between the Tata Group and the Tamil Nadu Industrial Development Corporation (TIDCO).

In the March quarter, total expenses of Titan jumped 85.16 per cent to Rs 25,579 crore.

Titan’s total consolidated income, which includes other income, climbed 80.3 per cent to Rs 27,104 crore in Q4 FY26.

For the entire FY26, Titan’s profit surged 52 per cent to Rs 5,073 crore. It was Rs 3,337 crore a year ago.

Its consolidated sales in FY26 advanced 34.4 per cent to Rs 76,797 crore.

Meanwhile, in a separate filing, Titan said its board has recommended a dividend of Rs 15 per Equity Share of Re 1.

Titan’s total consolidated income rose 44.62 per cent to Rs 88,136 crore for the financial year ended March 31, 2026.

Shares of Titan Company rose 4.76 per cent to close at Rs 4513.40 apiece on BSE.

India’s mining sector shifts beyond compliance-led approach to sustainability

NEW DELHI: India’s mining sector is moving beyond compliance-driven sustainability practices towards a data-led model focused on long-term performance, according to a report released on Friday.

The report, titled Mining 5.0-Emerging Mining Technologies by 2030, was prepared by Deloitte and the Indian Chamber of Commerce. It said environmental, social and governance (ESG) regulations are shifting from voluntary commitments to mandatory, data-driven compliance, led by Sebi’s Business Responsibility and Sustainability Reporting (BRSR) framework for the top 1,000 listed firms.

The report highlighted that requirements such as BRSR core disclosures, mandatory assurance for leading firms and digital compliance are accelerating efforts in carbon reduction, waste management, governance transparency and social accountability.

According to the report, the next growth opportunity lies in integrating existing technologies into unified operating systems rather than deploying isolated solutions.

It added that aligning data, analytics, artificial intelligence and governance across the mining value chain can improve decision-making and overall system performance.

AGENCIES

Iran wants oil tariffs paid in Chinese yuan – is power of US petrodollar in decline?

Iran has announced plans to introduce tariffs in the Strait of Hormuz as a form of reparations for the damage caused by the war

AUCKLAND: After weeks of blockades by Iran and the United States in the Strait of Hormuz, it’s clear the narrow waterway is now pivotal to the outcome of the conflict.

The US has begun to escort ships through the narrow passage, but behind the military manoeuvring lies a deeper development: energy security in the Persian Gulf is in a state of profound flux.

As well as the desire by both Iran and the US to control the global flow of oil, gas, helium and fertilisers from the region, the United Arab Emirates (a key US ally) has withdrawn from OPEC in what’s been called a major blow to the oil cartel.

On top of this, Iran has

announced plans to introduce tariffs in the Strait of Hormuz as a form of reparations for the damage caused by the war.

If imposed, these tariffs are estimated to be worth between \$40 billion and \$50 billion a year to Iran, and would potentially allow it to mitigate the impact of US economic sanctions.

Crucially, tariffs would be a way to cultivate stronger relations with China because they would be denominated in Chinese yuan, not US dollars. This has the potential to significantly alter regional and global power balances.

In fact, such payments have reportedly already been made by vessels going to China, India and Japan, with the Iranian par-

liament working to formalise the process. (Iran has also begun accepting payments in cryptocurrency.)

50 years of dominance

If Iran can continue to charge these tariffs, it could tilt regional influence away from the US towards China and Asia by eroding the historical dominance of the petrodollar.

Essentially, the petrodollar system has seen the pricing and trading of oil in US dollars. The term dates from the 1970s when the US asked Saudi Arabia to exclusively price its oil in US dollars in return for military aid.

This spread across OPEC (the Organisation of the Petroleum Exporting Countries), becoming the benchmark of the

CLOSER LOOK

- » If imposed, these tariffs are estimated to be worth between \$40 billion & \$50 billion a year to Iran
- » Tariffs would be denominated in Chinese yuan, not US dollars, with potential to significantly alter regional & global power balances
- » In fact, such payments have reportedly already been made by vessels going to China, India and Japan, with the Iranian parliament working to formalise the process

global oil trade, bolstering the US dollar as the global reserve currency and underwriting US power.

Oil-producing nations amassed huge petrodollar surpluses – too much to invest only in their own economies –

which were funnelled or “recycled” back into US securities and stocks, and other countries’ sovereign wealth funds.

They have become the primary source of revenue for OPEC members, as well as non-member oil exporters Qatar

and Norway. This ties these countries to Washington and gives the US significant financial leverage in global affairs. The flow of petrodollars helps finance US deficits and reduce US borrowing costs.

A new paradigm?

If major regional players such as the UAE, Bahrain, Qatar, Kuwait and Saudi Arabia pay Iranian tariffs in “petroyuans”, economist Antonio Bhardwaj has said, it would mark:

The systematic erosion of the petrodollar system and the emergence of the petroyuan as a credible, institutionally embedded alternative framework for settling global energy transactions.

It’s a sizeable “if”, but the

introduction of tariffs would also pose a dilemma for countries that supported Iran in the conflict (implicitly or explicitly) and those that didn’t.

As international relations analyst Pakizah Parveen has written, we would see the emergence of a bifurcated global oil market: barrels from compliant parties would move through Hormuz in yuan. In contrast, non-compliant parties would incur significantly higher costs in dollar-denominated barrels.

Such a choice would affect major US allies such as Pakistan, South Korea, Japan and the Philippines, all of which have faced severe economic pressures as a result of the upheavals in the Gulf and Middle East.

Paying tariffs in petroyuan would draw them towards China and play into Beijing’s narrative of being a reliable and more stable economic force. It also mirrors Russia’s request for payment in yuan for its oil since 2025.

Decline of the petrodollar

It would be premature to argue that Iranian tariffs will lead to a general “de-dollarisation” of the world economy. But they may be a step towards a devaluation of the US dollar.

By extension, any move by other countries away from the US dollar is a move away from dependence on the US financially and politically. It would also aid China’s push to internationalise the yuan.

AGENCIES

SBI March qtr profit rises 6% to ₹19,684 cr as bad loans decline

The country’s biggest lender had earned a profit of Rs 18,643 crore in the January–March period of financial year 2024–25

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: State Bank of India (SBI) on Friday reported a 6 per cent increase in stand-alone net profit at Rs 19,684 crore for the fourth quarter ended March 2026 aided by decline in bad loans.

The country’s biggest lender had earned a profit of Rs 18,643 crore in the January–March period of financial year 2024–25.

However, total income declined to Rs 1,40,412 crore in March quarter from Rs 1,43,876 crore in the same period a year ago, SBI said in a regulatory filing.

During the quarter, the bank earned an interest income of Rs 1,23,098 crore as against Rs 1,19,666 crore a year ago.

The bank saw an improvement in asset quality, with gross non-performing assets (NPAs) declining to 1.49 per cent of the total advances in the fourth quarter from 1.82 per cent as at March-end 2025. Similarly, net NPAs eased to 0.39 per cent from 0.47 per cent.

On a consolidated basis, SBI’s net profit in the quarter rose marginally to Rs 19,643



However, total income declined to Rs 1,40,412 crore in March quarter from Rs 1,43,876 crore in the same period a year ago, SBI said in a regulatory filing.

crore from Rs 19,600 crore a year ago.

Total income increased to Rs 1,81,079 crore from Rs 1,79,562 crore.

For entire financial year 2025–26, the bank reported 13 per cent increase in profit on a standalone basis at Rs 80,032 crore as against Rs 70,901 crore in the previous year.

The bank’s board has

declared a dividend of Rs 17.35 per equity share of face value of Re 1 per unit for FY26.

The record date for determining the eligibility of members entitled to receive dividend on equity shares is May 16 and dividend payment date is June 4, it said.

SBI shares were trading nearly 6 per cent lower at Rs 1,027.5 apiece on the BSE soon

Highlights

» During the quarter, the bank earned an interest income of Rs 1,23,098 crore as against Rs 1,19,666 crore a year ago

» Bank saw improvement in asset quality, with gross NPAs declining to 1.49% of total advances in Q4 from 1.82% in Q4 FY25

» On a consolidated basis, SBI’s net profit in Q4 rose marginally to Rs 19,643 cr from Rs 19,600 cr a year ago

average loan size increase to Rs 51 lakh now, compared to around Rs 35–40 lakh two years ago.

“...the definition of affordable homes is required to be changed. This is what we have been telling the government of India,” Setty told reporters at the customary post-earnings interaction.

He said the cost of housing is going up in the country, and hence, we need to revisit what qualifies as an affordable home.

At present, a home qualifies as affordable housing if its cost is up to Rs 45 lakh and the carpet area is up to a particular size.

Policy incentives for lenders financing affordable house purchases include treatment of the loans as priority sector lending and also tax tops.

“The cost of housing is going up; the concept of affordable homes has to be changed,” Setty said.

SBI reported a 13 per cent jump in its housing finance portfolio in FY26, and Setty said that a continued growth in the vertical is unlikely to move the net interest margins (NIMs) for the bank.

after results were announced.

Meanwhile, the bank on Friday sought a review of the affordable home definition, citing a sharp increase in its average home loan size in the recent past.

Chairman C S Setty said that the bank, which has the highest market share in the highly competitive affordable housing segment, has seen the

Markets fall for 2nd day amid renewed tensions in West Asia

Rupee appreciates by 71 paise to 93.51 against US dollar

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Equity markets stayed on the back foot for the second day on Friday as fresh geopolitical tensions in West Asia revived concerns over energy supplies and weighed heavily on investor sentiment.

Foreign fund outflows and a weak trend in global markets further added to the bearish trend.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 516.33 points, or 0.66 per cent, to settle at 77,328.19. During the session, it tumbled 698.09 points, or 0.89 per cent, to 77,146.43.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 150.50 points, or 0.62 per cent, to end at 24,176.15.

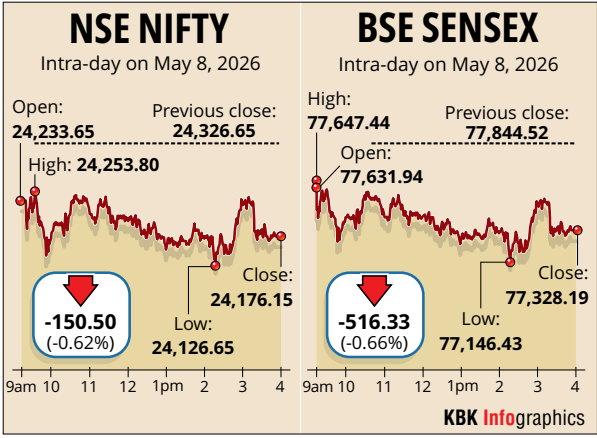
On the weekly front, the BSE benchmark climbed 414.69 points or 0.53 per cent, and the Nifty went up by 178.6 points or 0.74 per cent.

From the Sensex pack, State Bank of India tanked 6.62 per cent after its March quarter earnings.

HDFC Bank, Bajaj Finance, Axis Bank, UltraTech Cement and Mahindra & Mahindra were also among the laggards.

However, Titan jumped 4.76 per cent after the leading jewellery and watchmaker reported a 35.36 per cent increase in its consolidated net profit to Rs 1,179 crore for the March quarter of FY26.

Asian Paints, Adani Ports,



The BSE SmallCap Select index went up by 0.34 per cent, while the MidCap Select index dipped 0.01 per cent.

Infosys and HCL Tech settled in the positive territory.

“Markets witnessed a risk-off session following fresh US-Iran military action near the Strait of Hormuz, which weakened ceasefire hopes and triggered profit booking. However, stability in crude oil prices around USD 100 per barrel and benign US 10-year yields continue to provide support to the broader sentiment and the rupee,” Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments

Limited, said.

Though the road ahead is slightly bumpy, optimism around a possible diplomatic resolution persists, he added.

The BSE SmallCap Select index went up by 0.34 per cent, while the MidCap Select index dipped 0.01 per cent.

The rupee pared its losses and ended with a sharp gain of 71 paise at 93.51 against the US dollar on Friday amid a volatile situation in West Asia, triggering renewed concerns over energy supplies.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading 0.25 per cent lower at \$99.81 per barrel in the futures market.

Foreign institutional investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 340.89 crore on Thursday, according to exchange data.

Forex kitty drops by \$7.794 bn to \$690.693 bn

MUMBAI: India’s forex reserves dropped by \$7.794 billion to \$690.693 billion during the week ended May 1, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) said on Friday.

In the previous reporting week ended April 24, the overall reserves had declined by \$4.82 billion to \$698.487 billion.

The kitty had expanded to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion during the week ended February 27 this year before the beginning of the Middle East conflict, which led to several weeks of a drop as the rupee came under pressure and the RBI had to intervene in the forex market through dollar sales.

For the week ended May 1, foreign currency assets, a major component of the reserves, decreased by \$2.797 billion to \$551.825 billion, the central bank’s data showed.

Expressed in dollar terms, the foreign currency assets include effects of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units, such as the euro, pound, and yen, held in the foreign exchange reserves.

Value of gold reserves decreased by \$5.021 billion to \$115.216 billion during the week, the RBI said.

The Special Drawing Rights (SDRs) were up \$15 million to \$18.789 billion, the apex bank said.

India’s reserve position with the IMF was also up by \$8 million to \$4.863 billion at the end of the reporting week, the RBI data said. PTI

BoB Q4 profit rises 11% to ₹5,616 cr

NEW DELHI: Bank of Baroda (BoB) on Friday reported an 11.2 per cent rise in profit to Rs 5,616 crore during the March quarter.

The state-owned lender had earned a net profit of Rs 5,048 crore in the year-ago period.

During the quarter, the bank’s total income increased to Rs 36,609 crore, from Rs 35,852 crore a year ago, BoB said in a regulatory filing.

The bank’s interest income grew to Rs 32,642 crore, from Rs 30,642 crore in the fourth quarter of the previous financial year.

However, net interest income (NII) in the quarter declined to Rs 12,494 crore, from Rs 11,020 crore in the same period a year ago.

On the asset quality front, the bank’s gross non-performing assets (NPAs) moderated to 1.89 per cent of gross advances, as compared to 2.26 per cent by the end of March 2025.

Similarly, net NPAs came



For the entire fiscal 2024–25, the bank reported a 2 per cent increase in profit at Rs 20,021 crore, as against Rs 19,581 crore in the previous year

down to 0.45 per cent of the advances, over 0.58 per cent at the end of 2025.

The provision coverage ratio of the bank improved margin-

ally to 93.94 per cent as on March 31, 2026.

The bank’s capital adequacy ratio moderated to 15.82 per cent, from 17.19 per cent at the end of FY25.

For the entire financial year 2024–25, the bank reported a 2 per cent increase in profit at Rs 20,021 crore, as against Rs 19,581 crore in the previous year. The bank’s total income during the financial year rose to Rs 1,42,750 crore, as against Rs 1,38,089 crore a year ago.

The bank’s board has recommended a dividend of Rs 8.5 per equity share of face value of Rs 2 each for 2025–26, subject to shareholders’ approval.

Besides, the board approved raising of additional capital up to Rs 6,000 crore by way of Additional Tier 1 (AT1) and/or Tier-II bonds, in suitable tranches by March 2027 and beyond if found expedient, it said. This is subject to applicable statutory/regulatory approvals, it added. PTI

Zepto, 5 other cos secure Sebi’s nod for IPO

NEW DELHI: Six companies, including quick commerce unicorn Zepto and auto components maker Dhoot Transmission, have received approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) to raise funds through initial public offerings (IPOs).

The other firms that secured Sebi’s observations during May 4–8 are Horizon Industrial Parks, Surgiwear, Crystal Crop Protection and Hotel Polo Towers, according to an update by the regulator on Friday. In Sebi terminology, receiving observations amounts to approval for launching a public issue.

Zepto and Dhoot Transmission had filed their draft papers in December and February, respectively, through the confidential pre-filing route,



which allows companies to seek Sebi’s feedback without publicly disclosing their draft offer documents.

According to people aware of the matter, Zepto plans to raise Rs 11,000 crore through its IPO. If listed, the company will join rivals Zomato and Swiggy on the stock exchanges.

Private equity-backed Dhoot Transmission is looking to raise \$250 million (about Rs 2,258 crore) through a mix of fresh issue of shares and an

offer for sale (OFS). Sources said promoters will not dilute their stake in the OFS.

Blackstone-backed Horizon Industrial Parks plans to mobilise Rs 2,600 crore entirely through a fresh issue of equity shares, with no OFS component. As per the draft red herring prospectus (DRHP), nearly Rs 2,250 crore from the proceeds will be used to repay borrowings.

Uttar Pradesh-based Surgiwear has proposed an IPO comprising a fresh issue of shares worth up to Rs 370 crore and an OFS of up to Rs 370 crore by promoter Ghanashyam Das Agarwal. The proceeds will be utilised for machinery purchases, debt repayment and general corporate purposes.

Crystal Crop Protection

plans to raise Rs 600 crore through a fresh issue of shares. The IPO will also include an OFS of 74.05,387 shares by promoters and investors, including International Finance Corporation and IFC Emerging Asia Fund LP. The company intends to use the proceeds for debt repayment, funding inorganic growth and strategic initiatives, and general corporate purposes.

Hotel Polo Towers’ IPO comprises a fresh issue of Rs 300 crore and an OFS of 71.2 lakh shares by promoters. The company operates upscale and midscale hotels and resorts under the ‘Polo’ and ‘Max’ brands across northeast, east and north India. Shares of all six companies will be listed on the BSE and NSE. AGENCIES

Cancer Healer Center announces launch of its 27th center in Nashik

NASHIK: With cancer emerging as a major public health concern in India, the need for accessible and patient-centric care beyond metro cities is becoming increasingly important. According to the ICMR–NCDIR Maharashtra, the state is expected to record over 1.30 lakh new cancer cases in 2026, including 61,703 cases among men and 68,762 among women.

The report also identified key risk factors such as tobacco use, second-hand smoke exposure, obesity and lifestyle-related health conditions. Against this backdrop, Cancer Healer Center has launched a new facility in Nashik, tak-

ing its network to 27 centres across India. The centre aims to provide specialised cancer consultations, personalised treatment planning and follow-up care to patients in Nashik, North Maharashtra and nearby regions.

The company said regional centres are becoming increasingly important as families seek expert guidance, monitoring and supportive care without frequent travel to metropolitan cities. The Nashik facility will focus on personalised cancer care based on an immunology-informed approach, taking into account a patient’s disease profile, immunity, treatment his-

tory and overall quality of life.

Dr. Tarang Krishna, MD of Cancer Healer Center, said cancer care today extends beyond treatment and includes providing patients with clarity, confidence and continuity throughout their medical journey. He added that the Nashik centre aims to make specialised guidance and compassionate follow-up care more accessible for families in regional cities.

The announcement also follows the organisation’s association with the Sitar for Mental Health initiative, held across Delhi, Mumbai & Ahmedabad, featuring Rishab Rikhi-ram Sharma. MPOST

India seeks greater role in shaping global norms for fast-growing space industry

‘India stands at the forefront of global space transformation’

NEW DELHI: India is seeking a larger role in shaping international norms for the fast-growing space industry, a senior government official said on Friday, as global space standards experts gathered in New Delhi for a key ISO meeting.

The Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) organised the 35th Plenary and Working Groups meetings of ISO’s Technical Committee 20/Subcommittee 14 on Space Systems and Operations, drawing 131 international

delegates from 13 countries, including representatives from national standards bodies, space agencies, industry and academia.

In the opening session, Consumer Affairs Secretary Nidhi Khare said India stood “at the forefront of global space transformation”, citing policy reforms and the creation of IN-SPACe, a government body set up to promote private sector participation in the country’s space sector, an official statement said.

BIS Director General San-

jay Garg said the organisation was working to align Indian standards with international frameworks, adding that the New Delhi venue gave domestic experts direct access to the global standardisation process.

IN-SPACe Chairman Pawan Goenka stressed that robust standards were critical to enabling innovation and integrating India into the global space economy.

The subcommittee develops international standards cover-

ing the full lifecycle of space systems, from design and production through launch and operations, with a focus on safety, interoperability and sustainability.

The meeting also addressed emerging priorities such as space debris mitigation and long-term sustainability of orbital operations, areas where India has sought a more active international role alongside the achievements of state-run ISRO and a growing private industry. PTI

RBI eases norms on quarterly profits in bank capital

MUMBAI: The RBI on Friday relaxed norms for banks to include current year profits in their capital adequacy calculations on a quarterly basis by removing an additional qualifying condition linked to non-performing assets (NPAs).

Under existing rules, banks were allowed to include quarterly profits in capital calculations, subject to an extra condition related to asset quality. Through an amendment to capital adequacy norms, the RBI has now eased this requirement for inclusion of quarterly profits in Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1) capital.

According to the Reserve Bank of India (Commercial Banks – Prudential Norms on Capital Adequacy) Fifth Amendment Directions, 2026, banks can continue to reckon profits in the current financial year for capital to risk weighted assets ratio (CRAR) calculations every quarter, subject to prescribed conditions and formulae.

The norms also require banks to undertake an audit or limited review of quarterly financial statements. The RBI issued similar directions for small finance banks and payments banks. AGENCIES

Capitals get Finnished off

Spin choke and Allen's blitz power Knight Riders past Capitals

NEW DELHI: Kolkata Knight Riders' spinners strangled Delhi Capitals with a ruthless choke before Finn Allen unleashed a brutal six-hitting exhibition to power the visitors to a comfortable eight-wicket win and reignite their IPL play-off hopes here on Friday.

The spin trio of Anukul Roy (2/31), Sunil Narine (1/17) and Varun Chakravarthy (0/28), stifled Delhi's batting line-up, restricting them to a modest 142 for 8 despite a sparkling 29-ball 50 from Pathum Nissanka.

Impact substitute Allen then produced a fearless knock at the top. The Kiwi hit an astonishing 10 sixes and five fours in his unbeaten 47-ball 100 as KKR chased down the target on 14.2 overs.

The win, KKR's fourth on trot, catapulted them to seventh place while the loss, DC's seventh in 11 games this season, has all but killed their chances of making the playoffs.

Defending a below-par total, Delhi desperately searched for early breakthroughs and briefly found hope through moments of fortune. Ajinkya Rahane was run out after the ball brushed Mitchell Starc's fingertips onto the stumps at the non-striker's end, while Angkrish Raghuv



KKR's Finn Allen starred with a 47-ball ton against the hosts

PTI

vanshi was undone when the ball flicked his glove and rolled back onto the stumps.

But Allen's fearless stroke-play ensured KKR never lost sight of the chase as he dismantled the DC attack with clean hitting and aggressive intent.

Earlier, if it wasn't for Ashutosh Sharma's 39 off 28 balls which was laced with three boundaries and as many sixes, DC would have struggled to even cross the 100-run

mark. KKR's pacers complemented the spinners superbly, with Kartik Tyagi (2/25), Vaibhav Arora (1/29) and Cameron Green (1/12) striking at key moments to ensure Delhi never found sustained rhythm.

Asked to bat, Nissanka (50) and KL Rahul (23) provided Delhi a fluent start, with the Sri Lankan taking the aggressive route early, striking the innings' first boundary and six.

KKR, however, showed

complete faith in their spin resources from the outset, handing the ball to Roy and Narine inside the powerplay.

Though the Delhi openers negotiated the challenge well initially, the pressure steadily mounted as the spinners dried up the boundaries post the powerplay. Once Tyagi and Green removed Rahul and Nitish Rana (8) in quick succession, KKR unleashed their spin in full force.

AGENCIES

BCCI bars player room entries

NEW DELHI: Warning of potential "honey traps, legal liability and security risks", the BCCI has banned unauthorised visitors from the hotel rooms of players, support staff and team officials in the IPL after incidents of "misconduct and protocol violations" were flagged by the Board's Anti-Corruption Unit. In an elaborate advisory for the 10 IPL franchises, the BCCI has said that written authorisation from the team managers would be a must for guests to have access to the players' and officials' rooms.

"The advisory has been issued in light of certain incidents observed during ongoing season and is intended to reinforce the standards of professionalism, discipline, security awareness and protocol compliance expected from all stakeholders associated with IPL," secretary Devajit Saikia said.

AGENCIES

Titans target top-4 surge vs RR as mid-table fight intensifies

JAIPUR: An upbeat Gujarat Titans will be determined to continue their winning streak and leapfrog a wobbly Rajasthan Royals in their mid-table Indian Premier League clash here on Saturday.

Only the net run rate separates the 2022 edition winners Gujarat Titans (-0.147) from the fourth-placed 2008 champion Rajasthan Royals (0.510) in the points table as the two teams have fared alike so far. Both GT and RR have six wins and four defeats in 10 matches each.

But the Shubman Gill-led side will fancy their chances against the wobbly Royals, who have suffered three defeats in their last five matches. The Titans have racked up three wins on the trot and looking to break into the top four.

Royals captain Riyan Parag struck 90 in RR's first-innings score of 225 for six but it was not enough against Delhi Capitals who overhauled it with seven wickets and five balls to spare. It was the second such instance in a row when a first-innings total in excess of 220 could not be defended by the Royals. While RR are indeed top-heavy with Vaibhav Sooryavanshi (404 runs), Yashasvi Jaiswal (312) and even Dhruv



GT's Shubman Gill stretches during a practice session

PTI

Jurel (290) doing the heavy lifting, they will need their skipper to fire big in the lower order, which has only Donovan Ferreira (229) hitting at 150 or above.

Jurel has undoubtedly been a vital cog in the Royals' batting line-up, but the right-handed batter has been guilty of not accelerating at the top.

In his last three outings, Jurel has scored 42 off 30 balls, 16 off 20 balls, and 42 off 30 balls at No. 3 and these numbers certainly warrant further improvement in a season where no total, batting first, is safe. While the season has been even more severe on the bowlers, RR will have to find solutions of their bowling woes, especially in the middle overs.

AGENCIES

Archers Simranjeet, Sahil in medal race

SHANGHAI: Recurve archer Simranjeet Kaur and compound player Sahil Jadhav emerged as India's surprise standout performers in an otherwise patchy campaign, staying on course for their maiden Archery World Cup medals here on Friday.

Asian Games team bronze medallist Simranjeet, who narrowly missed a place in the Indian women's team after finishing three points behind Deepika Kumari in the qualification round, made the most of her individual opportunity by storming into the semifinals at the Stage 2 of the World Cup.

The 27-year-old from Haryana defeated Taiwanese teenager Fong You Jhu 6-0 (27-24, 28-26, 29-26) to move within one win of her maiden World Cup medal. Fong had earlier stunned India's top-ranked archer Ankita Bhakat in the second round. Simranjeet was at her consistent best, dropping just six points from nine arrows against the 19-year-old from Chinese Taipei in the quarters.

She now faces the toughest test of her career against world No. 1 Kang Chaeyoung in the semifinals. Even if she loses, she will still have a chance to secure bronze in the playoff.

AGENCIES

Gukesh takes down Caruana, is joint 4th

WARSAW: World champion D Gukesh defeated American Grandmaster Fabiano Caruana in the ninth and final round to be tied fourth in the Super Rapid and Blitz Tournament's rapid competition here, sustaining a welcome return to form after struggling for the past few months.

The Indian is tied fourth with 18 more rounds to come in the blitz section that follows the rapid event.

The 19-year-old Gukesh had started the final day of the rapid section with a loss against French Grandmaster Maxime Vachier-Lagrave and then in the penultimate round drew with Vladimir Fedoseev of Slovenia. Wildcard American Hans Moke Niemann yet again proved his detractors wrong



by emerging as the surprise winner of this section on 13 points in all. Niemann edged out compatriot Wesley So by a full point who ended second ahead of Fedoseev on 11.

"My rapid event was inconsistent. I was playing well, but I missed a few chances. There were also games where I was in trouble and managed to save. The tournament could have

been better," Gukesh said. Gukesh, Caruana and Duda Jan-Krzysztof of Poland tied for the fourth spot on nine points apiece and the main battle is likely to be between these six players once the blitz competition begins.

Gukesh got in to some initial trouble against Caruana who played the black side of a Benoni defense. The American won a pawn in the early middle game but Gukesh kept himself in the hunt by creating counter play on the queen side.

It was on the 38th move that Caruana erred decisively, overlooking a small tactic that allowed Gukesh to win a rook for a Bishop. The rest was a matter of technique and the Indian won after another 11 moves.

AGENCIES

Clashico in training

All's not well as Valverde hurt in altercation with Tchouaméni

MADRID: Real Madrid midfielder Federico Valverde suffered a head injury, the club said, in an altercation with teammate Aurélien Tchouaméni ahead of a weekend match against fierce rivals Barcelona.

It was the latest disruption to a Madrid squad that has endured a tough season that included lackluster results, a coaching change and fan criticism of stars such as Vinicius Junior, Jude Bellingham and Kylian Mbappé. Madrid could see Barcelona celebrate the league title in Sunday's clasico at the Camp Nou. The Catalan club needs only a draw to win its second league title in a row.

Madrid said in a statement Thursday that "following the incidents that occurred this morning during the first team's training session, it has decided to open disciplinary proceedings against our players Valverde and Tchouaméni."

Valverde downplayed the incident, saying on Instagram that no punches were thrown. He said he hurt his head after accidentally hitting a table during the encounter.

AGENCIES



Both players had disciplinary proceedings opened against them

millenniumpost CLASSIFIEDS

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Monika Sharma W/o Sh. Bhisham R/o V. Pelak Teh. Palwal, Distt. Palwal-121102, have change my name Monika Sharma to Meena. For All Purpose.

I, Vimlesh Devi, W/o Radheshaym Sharma, resident of Gram Keelpura mahwasala, Nadgawan, PO :Nadgawan, Distt:Agra, Uttar Pradesh-283114, have changed my name from Vimlesh Devi to Bimlesh Sharma. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Bimlesh Sharma for all future purposes.

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Tender Notice

Invitation of tender through E-tendering (e-Procurement Systems)

On behalf of President of India Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer, office at:- Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana Sonpat invites e-tender for below mentioned work:-

NIT No. : 365888

Name of Work and its location : "Ultrasonic testing (UST) of Wheel disc, Dye Penetrant testing (DPT) of underslung parts of LHB and VB coaches and Bogie frame parts and MPI/MPT testing of various components of LHB and VB coaches at RCNK (As per Scope of Work)"

Approx. Cost of work : Tender Cost: Rs. 45,89,764.64/- including GST@18% (Rupees Forty Five Lakh Eighty Nine Thousand Seven Hundred Sixty Four and Sixty Four Paisa Only)

Earnest Money : Rs. 91,800/-

Completion period of work : 12 months (01 Year) from date of issue of Letter of acceptance

Cost of Tender document : NIL

Date and time for submission of tender and opening of tender : Up to 15:00 hrs. on 01.06.2026 Opening of Tender at 15:15 hrs. on same day.

Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen : Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in

No. : 365888 Dated: 08.05.2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

OFFICE OF THE MUNICIPAL CORPORATION BHOPAL

Water Works Department

4th floor, BMC Head Office, Tuls Nagar, Bhopal
Ph.No.0755-2701669

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER

Online tenders are being invited for the following works. The bidder can obtained detailed information and tender documents on website <http://mptenders.gov.in>

Corrigendum for this NIT shall not be issued separately in newspapers. Corrigendum regarding correction can be seen on the website <http://mptenders.gov.in>

S. No.	NIT No.	Tender ID.	Details of Work	Estimated Cost (INR)	Earnest Money (EMD)	Bid Submission End Date
1	46/T.Sec./EE/W.W.D./2026-27 First call	2026_UAD_506029_1	Providing laying jointing and Commissioning of HDPE and DJ Pipe line at Shabri Nagar OHT Network Area Under Zone 16, Bhopal	1,84,04,260.00	92021.00	08.06.2026
2	48/T.Sec./EE/W.W.D./2026-27 First call	2026_UAD_506046_1	Providing laying jointing and Commissioning of HDPE and DJ Pipe line at Vishwakarma Nagar OHT Network Area Under Zone 17, Bhopal	1,71,15,376.00	85,577.00	08.06.2026

T.N.162/026/027

Sd/- Executive Engineer (WWD)
Municipal Corporation, Bhopal

Chhattisgarh State Industrial Development Corporation Limited

(A Government of Chhattisgarh Undertaking)
(ISO 9001 : 2015 Certified)
1st Floor, Udyog Bhawan, Ring Road No.1, Telibandha, Raipur (C.G.) - 492006
CIN : U45203CT1981SG001853, PAN : AABCM6288N, GST Regn No. 22AABCM6288N5Z Y
Phone : 0771-6621000 Fax : 0771-2583794
Website : www.csidc.in, Email address: csidc.cg@nic.in, csidc_raipur@yahoo.com

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (1st Call)

(e-Procurement Portal)

NIT No. 05 & 06/CSIDC/E.E./Div-IV/2026-27/System No. 190542 & 190544 Raipur, Dated 08/05/2026

Chhattisgarh State Industrial Development Corporation Ltd., Raipur (CSIDC), a Government of Chhattisgarh Undertaking constituted under the Companies Act, engaged in Industrial Infrastructure Development & Other Related Activities in the State invites online tender in "Form-B" (Item Rate Basis) for the following works:-

S. No.	Name of Work	Registered Contractor in CGPWD or in appropriate class in other dep't.	Time allowed including rainy season	P.A.C. (INR Lac)	EMD (INR Rs.)	Cost of Tender Doc. (INR) including GST 18%
1	Providing of labour for Clearing of Road Dust using Broom for air quality improvement at Industrial Area Borai Distt. Durg (C.G.) (Total Length of Road 15.00 K.M.)	D & Above	12 Months i/c Rainy Season	17.17 Lacs	12,900/-	1770/-
2	Sprinkling of Water through tractor Water Tanker for Air Quality improvement at Industrial Area Borai Distt. Durg (C.G.) complete for 1 year from the date of work order.	D & Above	12 Months i/c Rainy Season	50.65 Lacs	38,000/-	3540/-

The tender document containing detailed terms & conditions, scope of work and other details can be downloaded from the web portal (website) <https://eproc.csstate.gov.in> from 08/05/2026 and Time 17:01 and shall be submitted online only. Amendment in tender, if any, will only be uploaded on the website and shall not be published in any newspaper.

NOTE:- The interested tenderers for online submission of tender may contact CG eProc Helpdesk. Operated by Mjunction Services Limited., they may reach Helpdesk using 18002582502 (from 9 AM to 11 PM) (therein press 2 for CG e-Proc) or you can email them at Helpdesk.eproc@cgswan.gov.in.

samvad 47765/3 Executive Engineer, Division-IV

कार्यालय एवं दुकान हेतु स्थान उपलब्ध, वेबसाईट देखें www.csidc.in

झारखण्ड कर्मचारी चयन आयोग

कालीनगर, चायबगान, नामकोम, राँची-834010

क्रमांक-849 निविदा सूचना दिनांक-07.05.2026

झारखण्ड कर्मचारी चयन आयोग, राँची द्वारा अनुषंगीय/अप्रयुक्त (Unused) Aluminium Box (Big Size Box /Small Size Box/ Mini Size Box) का विक्रय करने हेतु निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा प्रपत्र झारखण्ड कर्मचारी चयन आयोग, कालीनगर, चायबगान, नामकोम, राँची-834010 स्थित कार्यालय (स्थापना शाखा) से कोरे कागज में आवेदन देकर तथा 1000/- (एक हजार रुपये) का राष्ट्रीयकृत बैंक के बैंक ड्राफ्ट जो राखिव, झारखण्ड कर्मचारी चयन आयोग, राँची के नाम से देय हो जमा करके दिनांक-11.05.2026 से 20.05.2026 तक कार्यालय दिवस में प्राप्त की जा सकती है। अन्य विवरण इस प्रकाश हे:-

क्रमांक	सामग्री का विवरण	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य	निविदा प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि	निविदा खोलने की तिथि
01	अनुषंगीय/अप्रयुक्त (Unused) Aluminium Box (Big Size Box /Small Size Box/ Mini Size Box)	1000/-	20.05.2026	21.05.2026

निविदा प्रपत्र एवं शर्तें आयोग की वेबसाईट- www.jssc.jharkhand.gov.in पर भी उपलब्ध है। निविदा कर्ता वेबसाईट से डाउनलोड किये गये निविदा प्रपत्र के साथ निविदा शुल्क के रूप में 1000/- रु का बैंक ड्राफ्ट सॉल्वन कर निविदा प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि के पूर्व आयोग कार्यालय में जमा करवा सकते हैं।

हो/- राखिव

PR 379281 (Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission)26-27*D झारखण्ड कर्मचारी चयन आयोग,राँची

झारखण्ड सरकार

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय

ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमण्डल, धनबाद

मोबाईल नं० : 7061981397 Email : rdsd.dhanbad@rediffmail.com

पत्रांक:- 435 धनबाद/दिनांक- 08.05.2026

अति अल्पकालीन निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

ई0- निविदा सूचना संख्या - 06/2026-27/RDSD/EE/Dhanbad/2nd Call

1.कार्य की विस्तृत विवरणी:-

क्र० सं०	कार्य का नाम	प्राक्कलित राशि (लाख में)	अग्रघन की राशि	परिमाण विपत्र का मूल्य	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि
1.	Construction of Health Sub Centre Under PM Ayushman Bharat Health Infrastructure Mission Scheme (PM-ABHIM) at Jamuatand Panchayat in Baghmara-cum-Katras Block Dhanbad District	55.50	परिमाण विपत्र की राशि 2%	10000.00	9 महीना
2.	Construction of Health Sub Centre Under PM Ayushman Bharat Health Infrastructure Mission Scheme (PM-ABHIM) at Muraidih Panchayat in Baghmara-cum-Katras Block Dhanbad District	55.50	परिमाण विपत्र की राशि 2%	10000.00	9 महीना

2. वेबसाईट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि -14.05.2026

3. ई-निविदा प्राप्ति की तिथि एवं समय-दिनांक 14.05.2026 से दिनांक 21.05.2026 को अपराह्न 5:00 बजे तक।

4. ई-निविदा खोलने का स्थान - कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय, ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमंडल, धनबाद।

5. ई-निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय-23.05.2026 अपराह्न 2:00 बजे

6. ई-निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का नाम एवं पता :- ई0 बेमौलाल मंडावी, कार्यपालक अभियंता, ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमंडल, धनबाद।

7. ई-निविदा प्रकोष्ठ का दूरभाष सं० - 7061981397 (संबंधित कार्यपालक अभियंता का दूरभाष नम्बर)

8. Office Help Line No. 9835146652

9. परिमाण विपत्र की राशि घट-बढ़ सकती है तदनुसार अग्रघन की राशि देय होगी।

10. जिस संवेदक का इस प्रमंडल में पूर्व से आवंटित कोई कार्य लंबित है अथवा उनका कार्यवाहन संतोषजनक नहीं रहा है, उन्हें कार्य आवंटन पर विचार नहीं किया जायेगा।

11. निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रघन की राशि केवल Online Mode द्वारा सीकरीय होगी।

12. निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रघन की राशि का ई-मुद्रातान जिस खाता से किया जायेगा, उसी खाते में अग्रघन की राशि वापस होगी। अगर खाता को बंद कर दिया जाता है तो सारी जबाबदेही आपकी होगी।

विस्तृत जानकारी के लिये वेबसाईट www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in एवं कार्यालय की सूचना पट्ट पर देखा जा सकता है।

कार्यपालक अभियंता
ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमंडल, धनबाद

PR 379349 Rural Development(26-27).D

‘SALMAN WAS KEEN TO STAR IN Raja Shivaji’

Khan prompted Riteish Deshmukh to craft a special role that justified the actor’s stardom

MUMBAI: Riteish Deshmukh said Salman Khan insisted on being part of ‘Raja Shivaji’, prompting him to craft a special role that justified the actor’s stardom. Released on May 1, the historical epic chronicles the life of the Maratha Empire’s founder, Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. Deshmukh not only stars in the titular role but has also co-written and directed it.

In ‘Raja Shivaji’, Salman is seen in a cameo appearance as Jiva Mahala, a brave warrior who saved Shivaji Maharaj’s life in the battle of Pratapgad. “Salman told me one day that he has to be in ‘Raja Shivaji’. I had not thought about it, but he said, ‘You cannot make a movie without me, I have to be part of the film’. I told him, ‘Give me some time’, because if he’s coming on screen, then it has to be worth something. People should enjoy it because it’s Salman Khan, eventually,” Deshmukh told PTI.



In the film, Salman is seen in a cameo appearance as Jiva Mahala

The actor-director said he didn’t want Salman to simply be himself on screen but to embody a character that would resonate with the audience. “I didn’t want him to be Salman; I wanted him to be a character. The character has to be bigger than Salman Khan and at the same time, the fans should enjoy. So, we had this part. I knew that I needed one line that fit. When it appeared on screen and when it landed the way we wanted, it was just wonderful.”

Salman has previously made cameo appearances in Deshmukh’s 2022 directorial debut ‘Ved’ in a special song and in ‘Lai Bhaari’, which marked Deshmukh’s debut in Marathi cinema.

‘Raja Shivaji’ boasts of a star-studded cast including Salman, Sanjay Dutt as Afzal Khan, Abhishek Bach-

chan as Sambhaji Shahaji Bhonsale, Vidya Balan as Badi Begum, Fardeen Khan as Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan, Amole Gupte as Adil Shah and others.

Deshmukh said his actor friends from the Hindi movie industry came on board for the movie purely out of love and respect and without charging any penny. “I don’t think one can describe what kind of bond this is. This is just an unsaid and unconditional kind of love and respect that you have for each other. Like, if tomorrow Abhishek or Salman Bhau tells me, ‘What about this?’ I’ll say yes without even thinking. If he has thought of me, then I have to be there. So, that’s the bond we have for each other, I respect that.”

PTI



I was miscast: Sai Pallavi

The actress said someone else should have done the film ‘Ek Din’, which also stars Junaid Khan

Last Friday marked Sai Pallavi’s debut in Bollywood with the Aamir Khan-backed romantic drama ‘Ek Din’, co-starring Junaid Khan. While the film has received a lukewarm response at the box office and mixed to negative reviews, Sai recently made candid remarks during promotions, suggesting she felt she may have been miscast in the project.

In a conversation with her co-star Junaid Khan on the ‘YouTube’ channel ‘Aamir Khan Talkies’, Sai reflected on her experience of working in the film and her own self-critique of her performance. Recalling the experience, she said, “I think I’m a little extra serious when it comes to a few scenes which should have been done easily. And I think I was miscast.”

She further described her reaction after watching the film with Aamir Khan for the first time: “I was just quiet for a while and he was like, ‘Say something’. And I told him that I don’t think I was meant to do this and I think I am miscast. He was like, ‘What are you saying?’ I think it should have been a new person who had a little bit of flamboyance. I think somebody else was meant to do this film.”

Junaid Khan, however, strongly disagreed with her assessment and defended her performance. Responding to her comments, the actor said, “I fight with papa over a lot of things, but here I agree with him.”

AGENCIES



Sai reflected on her experience of working in the film and her own self-critique of her performance

Paul Mescal to star in ‘Hold on to Your Angels’



LOS ANGELES: Oscar-winner Jessie Buckley is set to reunite with her ‘Hamnet’ co-star Paul Mescal for director Benh Zeitlin’s ‘Hold on to Your Angels’.

Buckley won the ‘Best Actress’ Oscar for her role in Chloe Zhao’s critically acclaimed historical drama. Based on Maggie O’Farrell’s novel, the story is a dramatised retelling of William Shakespeare and his wife, Agnes Hathaway, as they struggle with the death of their 11-year-old son, Hamnet.

The two actors also starred in Maggie Gyllenhaal’s ‘The Lost Daughter’ but had no scenes together.

‘Hold on to Your Angels’ will be produced by ‘Plan B’ and ‘Rapt Film’, according to the entertainment news outlet ‘Deadline’. The story revolves around a hell-bound outlaw (Mescal) and a ferocious shepherd of lost souls (Buckley), who fall into a catastrophic love, as per the official logline.

“‘Hold on to Your Angels’ is the most impossible love story I’ve ever witnessed - an outlaw romance for the end of America, set on the crumbling edge of South Louisiana,” the filmmaker said.

PTI

MOTHER’S DAY AT EDESIA

From her favourite flavours to family moments

OUR CORRESPONDENT

This Mother’s Day, celebrate the most special woman in your life with an indulgent brunch experience at Edesia. On May 10, from 12:30 pm to 4 pm, guests are invited to come together for an afternoon of delectable cuisine, warm hospitality and memorable family moments.

Curated specially for the occasion, the Mother’s Day Brunch at Edesia promises an elaborate spread featuring global favourites, live stations, decadent desserts, refreshing beverages and thoughtfully crafted delicacies designed to make mothers feel truly celebrated.

Set in an elegant and vibrant ambience, the brunch aims to create meaningful experiences for families looking to honour the unconditional love and warmth of mothers over great food and togetherness.



On May 10, from 12:30 pm to 4 pm, guests are invited to come together for an afternoon of delectable cuisine

Whether it’s a grand family gathering or an intimate celebration, Edesia offers the perfect setting to make Mother’s Day extra special.

For reservations and more information, contact: +91 95829 44897



The festival will be held until May 17 from 7 pm to 11 pm at Viva All Day Dining restaurant

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Holiday Inn Gurugram Sector 90 proudly presents Jashn-e-Awadh Food Festival, a grand celebration of the rich culture and timeless culinary heritage of Awadh. The festival will be held until May 17 from 7 pm to 11 pm at Viva All Day Dining restaurant, which will be beautifully decked in an Awadhi theme to enhance the ambience and create an immersive dining experience. The festival promises a rich gastronomic journey showcasing authentic recipes, traditional cooking styles and the warmth of Awadh hospitality.

Curated by Executive Chef Prakash Yadav in collaboration with Chef Mohammad Ramzan Qureshi from Crowne Plaza Lucknow, the food festival brings

together authentic Awadhi flavours and time-honoured recipes that have been cherished and passed down through generations.

Guests are invited to embark on a sensory journey where every course unfolds like a cherished memory from the region’s vibrant streets and royal kitchens. The experience begins with a sip of ‘Sharbat-e-Mohabbat’, delicately sweet and fragrant with dried rose petals, offering a refreshing welcome steeped in old-world charm. This is followed by the timeless ritual of ‘Hazratganj Ki Chai’ paired with warm ‘Bun Makkhan’.

As the feast unfolds, rich aromas and slow-cooked flavours take centre stage. The rich ‘Dai Sultani’, indulgent ‘Kofta-e-Shaan’, fragrant ‘Awadhi Korma’ and the iconic ‘Nalli Nihari’ showcase the refinement of Awa-



dhi culinary traditions, while the celebrated ‘Lucknow Dum Biryani’ arrives layered with delicate spices and nostalgic warmth.

The journey concludes on a sweet note with traditional desserts such as ‘Shaahi Tukda’, ‘Jalebi Dahi’, ‘Imarti and Rabri’, each bite leaving behind the warmth, richness and timeless elegance of the region’s culinary heritage.

Speaking about the festival, Prakash Yadav, Executive Chef,

said, “Jashn-e-Awadh is our tribute to the royal kitchens of Awadh. We have focused on preserving authenticity while creating an experience that delights modern diners.”

Krishan Kumar, Food & Beverage Manager, added, “We are excited to bring this unique culinary journey to our guests. The festival is designed not just as a dining experience, but as a celebration of Awadhi culture, hospitality and flavours.”

With its rich menu, authentic preparation and warm hospitality, Jashn-e-Awadh Food Festival promises to be an unmissable experience for food enthusiasts and connoisseurs alike.

For reservations and more information, please contact: Holiday Inn Gurugram Sector 90 Sapphire 90, Sector 90, Gurugram, Haryana - 122505 T: 8929669236, 8929669237

‘SRK gave us the room to make Kartavya on our own’

Saif Ali Khan stars in the film along with Rasika Dugal

MUMBAI: Saif Ali Khan said producer Shah Rukh Khan gave the team of ‘Kartavya’ a free hand to make the film the way they wanted. In fact, Shah Rukh was the one who called Saif to inform him about the script that they were developing at ‘Red Chillies’.

“He said, ‘There’s a lovely script and I would like you to hear it and do it’. Then I listened to it and met the director. Once the film was complete, he said, ‘It has come out as a lovely movie’. He was very happy,” Saif said.

Saif added, “Sometimes the presence of Shah Rukh can be overwhelming on sets and I think he understands that. He gave us room to make the film on our own. I felt I was working for his production with his kind of sensibility.”

Directed by Pulkit of ‘Bhakshak’

fame, the film stars Rasika Dugal opposite Saif and the actor said he is a huge fan of the ‘Mirzapur’ star. “It was elevating to work with Dugal. When you work with an artist of this calibre and Rasika is such a wonderful actor, I was challenged and tried my best and it brought out the good work in me also. I’m a big fan of hers and it was nice working with her,” the actor said at the trailer preview of the movie.

Dugal said she has long admired Saif and had a fun experience working with him. “I’ve been an admirer of his work for many years. I had heard that Saif is the most fun co-actor to work with and that was true and more. He has a fantastic sense of humour and he brought in a certain energy to the set, which was beautiful. I wish we had more days to shoot. We unanimously agree that he is handsome,” she said.

Produced by Gauri Khan under ‘Red Chillies Entertainment’, ‘Kartavya’ follows a police officer (Saif) as he navigates rising threats while grappling with the weight of his duty and the safety of his family.

PTI

Shah Rukh was the one who called Saif to inform him about the script that they were developing at ‘Red Chillies’



**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**

E-Tendering Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and on behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-N-2026-101	
Description of work: Zone No. 3A:- Annual sectional contract for repair and maintenance, white wash, colour wash, distemper showern, painting & polishing and supply of material work for SSE (Works) ML Gwalior section i.e. Sithouli-Gwalior-Birlanagar & IRCAMTECH area under ADEN/GWL for the year 2026-27	
Approx Cost : ₹ 12600000.00	Earnest Money: ₹ 252000.00
Date of closing Tender: 28.05.2026 at 15.00 hrs.	
Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter: 12 Months	
E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-N-2026-102	
Description of work: Zone No. 3B:- Annual sectional contract for repair and maintenance, white wash, colour wash, distemper showern, painting & polishing and supply of material work for SSE (Works) NG Gwalior section i.e. BLNR (Excl.)-UDMR (Excl.) section under ADEN/GWL for the year 2026-27	
Approx Cost : ₹ 6400000.00	Earnest Money: ₹ 128000.00
Date of closing Tender: 28.05.2026 at 15.00 hrs.	
Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter: 12 Months	
E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-N-2026-103	
Description of work: Zone No. 4:- Annual sectional contract for supply for material & repair and maintenance work under ADEN/Line/Jhansi between Jhansi (Excl. Jhansi Yard) to Sithouli (Excl.) for the year 2026-27	
Approx Cost : ₹ 9000000.00	Earnest Money: ₹ 180000.00
Date of closing Tender: 28.05.2026 at 15.00 hrs.	
Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter: 12 Months	
E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-N-2026-104	
Description of work: Zone No. 5:- Annual sectional contract for supply for material & repair and maintenance work under ADEN/GWL from Birlanagar (Excl.) to DHO (Excl.) section for the year 2026-27	
Approx Cost : ₹ 4000000.00	Earnest Money: ₹ 80000.00
Date of closing Tender: 28.05.2026 at 15.00 hrs.	
Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter: 12 Months	
* Tender online can be submitted upto to 15:00 hrs on 28.05.2026 * For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in .	
1020/26 FA	
North central railways @ CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in	

S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER

Tender Notice No.: TRD-RNC-26-27-01,
Dt-07.05.2026. For and on behalf of the President of India, the Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (TRD), South Eastern Railway, Ranchi-834003 for & on behalf of President of India, invites E-tender for the following work: **Name of work:** Manning/upkeeping of non-core electric traction assets of six OHE cum PSI Depots at Hatia, Bano, Govindpur Road, Muri, Lohardaga and Gola Road Stations in Ranchi Division for three years. **Tender Value:** ₹ 2,14,67,093. **EMD value:** ₹ 2,57,300. **Tender Closing Date & Time:** 29.05.2026 at 15.00 hrs. Tenderers can visit the website www.ireps.gov.in for online tendering. **(PR-145)**

**ICICI Bank**

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Sunil Puri-Deceased (Through His Legal Heir)/ Rajni Puri/ LBDEL00001434668	Flat No. B-2030, 2nd Floor, Type- B, Block- B, Sri Krishna Lok, Situated At National Highway- 2, Delhi- Agra Expressway At Vrindavan District Mathura Uttar Pradesh 281001/ May 06 2026	January 28, 2026 / Rs.19,42,899/-	Delhi/ NCR/ Mathura

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: May 09, 2026
Place: Delhi/Ncr

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Pardeep S/o Om Prakash R/o C-1/236, Nand Nagri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 494/2020 U/S 33 D Ex., Act PS: Welcome, Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Pardeep** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Pardeep** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Pardeep** accused of **FIR No. 494/2020 U/S 33 D Ex., Act PS: Welcome, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.06.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
JMFC-03, Room No. 19
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/5943/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Jatin Katyal S/o Rajpal Katyal R/o H. No. 11/88, Geeta Colony, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 388/24 U/s 420/468/471/120B IPC, PS Jagat Puri, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Jatin Katyal** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Jatin Katyal** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Jatin Katyal in FIR No. 388/24 U/s 420/468/471/120B IPC, PS Jagat Puri, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **27.06.2026**.

By order
Ms. Anushtha Srivastava
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
Room No. 7, Shahdara District
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/6070/SHD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC / 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Nasim @ Javed S/o Md. Tahir, R/o H.No. K-113, Idgah Road, Janta Majdoor Colony, Welcome, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 884/2023, U/S 25/54/59A Act, PS Welcome, North-East Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Nasim @ Javed** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Nasim @ Javed** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant); Proclamation is hereby made that **Nasim @ Javed** the said accused of **FIR No. 884/2023, U/s 25/54/59A Act, PS Welcome, North-East Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **09.06.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03,
Room No.-19, 1st Floor, Shahdara Distt.,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/5933/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. Pc/84 Bhartiya Nagarik Surkhasha Sanhita

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person Namely **Bhupinder W/o Kamal Sharma R/o E-73, Peera Garhi camp, Rohtak Road, Paschim vihar, Delhi** have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **CC No. 2612/2021 U/s 138 NI Act** has been registered at **P.S. Tilak nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Bhupinder** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Bhupinder** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Bhupinder** of under **CC No. 2612/2021 U/s 138 NI Act** has been registered at **P.S. Tilak nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **11.06.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Anshul Singhal,
JMFC-04, (West), Room No. 268,
Tis hazari court, Delhi

DP/6094/WD/2026
(Court notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Prakash Kumar, S/o: Ravi Lal, R/o: H.No-803, Near Block Stand Village, Alipur, Delhi-110036** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **Case No.: 1703/20, U/s: 138 NI Act, P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Prakash Kumar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Prakash Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Prakash Kumar** of **P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **11.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Jyoti Nain
JMFC-07, North, Room No. 06, 1st Floor,
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/6101/ON/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Badri Lal Teli, S/o: Mohan Teli, R/o: Gali No. 13, Brahmपुरi, Delhi** have committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 156/2024, U/s 283 IPC, P.S.: Jafraabad, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Badri Lal Teli** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Badri Lal Teli** have absconded (or are concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Badri Lal Teli** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 156/2024, U/s 283 IPC, P.S.: Jafraabad, Delhi** and are required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **12.06.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Anushtha Srivastava
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
Room No. 07, Karkardoom Court, Delhi

DP/6057/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

**Arcil**

Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Ltd. (Arcil)
Acting in its capacity as Trustee of various Arcil Trusts
Arcil office : The Ruby, 10th floor, 29, Senapati Bapat Marg, Dadar (West), Mumbai - 400 028.
Website : <https://auction.arcil.co.in>; CIN - U65999MH2002PLC134884

PUBLIC NOTICE FOR SALE THROUGH ONLINE E-AUCTION IN EXERCISE OF THE POWERS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 (SARFASIA ACT) READ WITH RULES 6, 8 & 9 OF SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and to the Borrower (s) / Guarantor (s) / Mortgage (s), in particular, that the below described immovable properties mortgaged / charged to the Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Limited, acting in its capacity as Trustee of various Arcil Trusts ("ARCIL") (pursuant to the assignment of financial asset vide registered Assignment Agreements), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is", "Whatever there is" and "Without recourse basis" by way of online e - auction, for recovery of outstanding dues together with further interest, charges and costs etc., as detailed below in terms of the provisions of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 ("Act") read with Rules 6, 8 and 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 ("Rules").

Name of the Borrower / Co - Borrower/s / Guarantor/s / Mortgage/s	LAN No. & Selling Bank	Trust Name	Outstanding Amount as per SARFASIA Notice Dated 27.12.2023 Respectively	Possession Type and Date	Date of Inspection	Type of Property and Area	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)	Reserve Price	Date & Time of E-Auction
Borrower : 1. NIDHI SRIVASTAVA 2. TULASI PATWAL @ TULSI PATWAL	Loan Account No. HHLNOD00277732 Sammaan Capital Limited (SCL) [formerly known as Indiabulls Housing Finance Limited]	Arcil - Trust - 2025-007	Rs. 26,53,781.91/- (Rupees Twenty Six Lakh Fifty Three Thousand Seven Hundred Eighty One and Paise Ninety One Only) as on 27.12.2023 + further Interest thereon + Legal Expenses	Physical possession on 21.01.2026	Will be arranged on request	Freehold - 796.72 sq. ft. (super built - up area)	Rs. 3,00,000/- (Rupees Three Lakh only)	Rs. 30,00,000/- (Rupees Thirty Lakh only)	On 08.06.2026 at 05:30 P.M.

Description of the Secured Asset being auctioned :
PLOT NO. D - 247, ENTIRE SECOND FLOOR (H.I.G. FLAT), ADMEASURING 70 SQUARE METERS (WITH ROOF RIGHTS), BLOCK - D, IN THE COLONY KNOWN AS SWARN JAYANTI PURAM, PARGANA DASNA, GHAZIABAD - 201011, UTTAR PRADESH. PLOT NO. D - 247 IS BOUNDED AS FOLLOWS :- EAST : ROAD 12 METERS WIDE; WEST : PLOT NO. 226; NORTH : PLOT NO. 248; SOUTH : PLOT NO. 246.

Pending Litigations known to ARCIL	Nil	Encumbrances / Dues known to ARCIL	Nil
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Last Date for submission of Bid	Same day 2 hours before Auction	Bid Increment amount :	As mentioned in the BID document
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Demand Draft to be made in name of : ARCIL - TRUST - 2025-007 Payable at par

RTGS details ARCIL - TRUST - 20250007, Trust Account No. – 57500001510599, HDFC Bank Limited, Branch : Kamla Mills, Mumbai, IFSC Code : HDFC0000542.

Name of Contact person & number Babu Khan - 0124-6910910; +91 70654 51024 (auctionhelpline@sammaancapital.com)

Terms and Conditions :

- The Auction Sale is being conducted through e-auction through the website <https://auction.arcil.co.in> and as per the Terms and Conditions of the Bid Document, and as per the procedure set out therein.
- The Authorised Officer ("AO") / ARCIL shall not be held responsible for internet connectivity, network problems, system crash down, power failure etc.
- At any stage of the auction, the "AO" may accept / reject / modify / cancel the bid / offer or post - pone the Auction without assigning any reason thereof and without any prior notice.
- The successful purchaser / bidder shall bear any statutory dues, taxes, fees payable, applicable GST on the purchase consideration, stamp duty, registration fees, etc. that is required to be paid in order to get the secured asset conveyed / delivered in his / her / its favour as per the applicable law.
- The intending bidders should make their own independent enquiries / due diligence regarding encumbrances, title of secured asset and claims / rights / dues affecting the secured assets, including statutory dues, etc., prior to submitting their bid. The auction advertisement does not constitute and will not constitute any commitment or any representation of ARCIL. The Authorized Officer of ARCIL shall not be responsible in any way for any third - party claims / rights / dues.
- The particulars specified in the auction notice published in the newspaper have been stated to the best of the information of the undersigned; however undersigned shall not be responsible / liable for any error, misstatement or omission.
- The Borrower / Guarantors / Mortgagees, who are liable for the said outstanding dues, shall treat this Sale Notice as a notice under Rules 8 and 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, about the holding of the above mentioned auction sale.
- In the event, the auction scheduled hereinabove fails for any reason whatsoever, ARCIL has the right to sell the secured asset by any other methods under the provisions of Rule 8(5) of the Rules and the Act.

Place : GHAZIABAD
Date : 24.04.2026

Sd/-
Authorized Officer
Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Ltd.

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**

Letter No. : DRM/CI/AGRA/PAY & USE/POLICY/2024 **Date :** 05.05.2026

E-Auction Notice

On Behalf of the President of India, The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manger-North Central Railway-Agra invites E-Auction as per categories given as under:-

Category : Cloak Room	Auction Catalogue No. : CLOAK-MTJ-26-01
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Asset Details : Manning of Cloak Room on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis at Mathura Jn. Railway Station.

E-Auction Start Date and Time : Date : 22.05.2026 Time : 12:30

E-Auction End Date and Time : Date : 22.05.2026 Time : 13:00

Note : Prospective bidders are requested to visit E-Auction Leasing Module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. 1018/26 (C)

North central railways @ www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPRONCR

**ICICI Bank**

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Ltd., BP-4, Technopolis Building, 4th Floor, Sector V, Salt Lake City, Kolkata West Bengal- 700091, CIN No: L65190GJ1994PLC021012, www.icicibank.com

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Anand Mishra/ Jyoti Mishra/ Mig 103, Phase-I Around Mandir Gorakhpur District - Gorakhpur Uttar Pradesh Gorakhpur- 273001/ TBCAL00006564052	"Dharitri Titanium", Flat No. E3, 4th Floor, Block No. 1, Holding No. 17, Methopara Road, C.S, Dag No. 1266, Khatian No. 903, R.S./L.R. Dag No. 1268, Khatian No. 904, R.S./L.R. Dag No. 1262, 1263, 1265, R.S./L.R. Khatian No. 25, Re. Sa, No. 132 & 139, J.L. No. 45, Touzi No. 146, Mouza Doharia, Village Methopara, P.S. Barasat, Madhyamgram Municipality, A.D.S.R.O. Barasat, District North 24 Parganas, West Bengal (addressing An Area of 1016 Sq Ft Super Built Up Area More or Less Along With One Car Parking Space At Ground Floor, Block 1, Area About 135 Sq Ft Super Built Up Area (Position Will Be Allotted As Per Developer Choice) North:20 Feet Wide Municipal Road South: R.S. Dag No. 1261 East: Part of R.S. Dag Nos. 1264, 1265, 1266 & 1267 West: Part of R.S. Dag Nos. 1269, 1270, 1271 & 1262/ Date of Symbolic 05/05/2026	November 25, 2025 Rs. 31,72,950.00/-	Gorakhpur/ Kolkata/ Noida
2.	Mani Shankar Sharma/ Rasulpur Chokmone Urf Dargah, District Mau Uttar Pradesh Mau- 273603/ TBCAL00006875054/ LBCAL00006901715	"Dharitri Titanium", Flat No. A-2(2), 3rd Floor, Block No. 1, Holding No. 17, Methopara Road, C.S, Dag No. 1266, Khatian No. 903, R.S./L.R. Dag No. 1268, Khatian No. 904, R.S./L.R. Dag No. 1262, 1263, 1265, R.S./L.R. Khatian No. 25, Re. Sa, No. 132 & 139, J.L. No. 45, Touzi No. 146, Mouza Doharia, Village Methopara, P.S. Barasat, Madhyamgram Municipality, A.D.S.R.O. Barasat, District North 24 Parganas, West Bengal, (Addressing An Area of 768 Sq Ft Super Build Up Area More or Less Along With Garage Including All The Proportionate Undivided Indivisible Share In The Land Comprised In Th Eplinth Area of The Flat, North:20 Feet Wide Municipal Road South: R.S. Dag No. 1261, East: Part of R.S. Dag Nos. 1264, 1265, 1266 And 1267, West: Part of R.S. Dag Nos. 1269, 1270, 1271 And 1262/ Date of Symbolic 05/05/2026	January 27, 2026 Rs. 32,71,229.99/-	Mau/ Kolkata/ Gurgaon

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: May 09, 2026
Place: Noida & Gurgaon

Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

From Unauthorized to Empowered: A New Chapter of Urban Transformation Begins in the Capital

DELHI SAYS FROM THE HEART: “THANK YOU, MODI JI”

“

This now brings an end to the decades of uncertainty and now gives them a chance to pursue the dreams of their lives in peace, without any threat of eviction or displacement. This would change the **fortune of entire Delhi**. And thill the fortune of Delhi changes, the country's fortune will not change.

”

- Narendra Modi, Prime Minister





A NEW DAWN FOR 900,000 FAMILIES

For over 4.5 million people living in unauthorized colonies, a new era has begun. These residents have long lived in uncertainty and insecurity. With legal recognition now in place, not only are their property rights strengthened, but they are also gaining social and economic stability. A dream that remained incomplete for years is finally turning into reality. This is not merely regularization—it is the restoration of dignity, security, and rights.

— CM Rekha Gupta



For years, millions of families living in unauthorized colonies in Delhi were caught in a strange paradox—they had homes, yet no legal ownership. There was no clear property title, no full access to government services, and no sense of security about the future.

Today, under the visionary leadership of Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, Delhi is witnessing a historic transformation where dreams are finally being recognized by law, and homes are being honored with rightful ownership.

This is not just a policy decision; it is an effort to restore identity, dignity, and security to millions who have waited for decades.

Because now, their homes are no longer just places to live—they are legally theirs. And across the streets of Delhi, a new voice echoes: “Thank you, Modi Ji!”

PM-UDAY: A DREAM REALIZED

Launched in 2019, the Pradhan Mantri Unauthorized Colonies in Delhi AwasAdhikar Yojana (PM-UDAY) has granted ownership rights to lakhs of families for the first time. So far, around 40,000 conveyance deeds have been issued. However, due to technical and procedural complexities, progress had been relatively slow.

Now, by removing these bottlenecks, the government has accelerated the scheme with renewed momentum.

“AS-IS WHERE-IS” — THE GUARANTEE OF THE BIGGEST CHANGE

Out of Delhi's 1,731 unauthorized colonies, 1,511 will now be regularized on an “as-is where-is” basis.

What does this mean?

- No requirement for layout plans
- Existing homes will be considered legally valid
- All plots approved for residential use
- Relief extended to small shops

This is not just a reform—it is a guarantee of real change in people's lives.

Not Just Homes, It's a Vikas Ki Guarantee

With regularization, these colonies will now see structured development by government agencies. Earlier, unclear legal status limited development. Now, infrastructure investment will increase.

What has changed?

- MCD will issue Regularisation Certificates
- Revenue Department will provide Conveyance Deeds and Authorization Slips
- Infrastructure development will be ensured

NOW, COLONIES WILL HAVE:

- Better roads
- Safer streets
- Modern amenities

A New Vision for Delhi: TOD Policy

While rights are being granted, the future is also being strengthened. Enter the Transit Oriented Development (TOD) Policy. This policy aims to integrate transport and housing by promoting high-density, planned development around metro and transit corridors. It enables people to live closer to transit, improving ease of living and encouraging walkability.

What will change?

- Affordable housing options
- Better connectivity
- Smart and planned urban growth

A New Era of Affordable Housing

UNDER THE NEW POLICY:

- Development within 500 meters on both sides of Metro/RRTS corridors
- Around 207 sq. km area opened for development
- Smaller plots (minimum 2000 sq. m) now eligible
- Maximum FAR increased up to 500
- 65% FAR mandatory for residential use
- Promotion of affordable housing units (< 99 sq. m)
- Remaining FAR allowed for commercial and flexible use

Regularization of unauthorized colonies and the TOD policy together will redefine housing, urban development, and ease of living in Delhi. This is not just about regularization—it is a step toward an inclusive, planned, and modern urban model that ensures better quality of life and infrastructure.

Now Every Family's Dream of “Owning a Home” Will Come True

A Major Step Toward Inclusive Development Earlier, several areas were excluded from the TOD policy. Now, an additional 80 sq. km has been included.

THIS MEANS:

- Unauthorized colonies enter the mainstream of development
- Land pooling areas are now included

Now, Delhi's landscape will change—and so will its mindset. Because this is no longer just about homes—it's about the future of the entire city.

THIS INITIATIVE WILL:

- Transform unplanned growth into organized development
- Empower citizens
- Elevate Delhi to a world-class city

FASTER, TRANSPARENT, AND SIMPLER PROCESSES

Where files once took months, work will now be completed in days:

- GIS survey report in 7 days
- Deficiency Resolution Memo in 15 days
- Conveyance deed issued within 45 days
- Mandatory maintenance of PM-UDAY register

ADDITIONALLY:

- ADM appointed as the single nodal officer
- Surveys conducted at the local level
- Online applications through the SWAGAM portal

With digital tracking and application systems, transparency has increased, and citizens no longer need to run from office to office. This is the new system of a double-engine government—simple, fast, and reliable.

APPLICATIONS OPEN ON THE SWAGAM PORTAL FROM APRIL 24, 2026—YOUR RIGHTS, NOW IN YOUR HANDS

- No long queues...
- No middlemen...
- Just one click—and your home becomes legally yours.



NOW DELHI SAYS—THANK YOU, MODI JI

When a family smiles holding the legal papers of their home...
When a young person begins planning their future...
When the first ray of development reaches a colony...
One voice echoes from every heart: “Thank you, Modi Ji!”

“THIS IS NOT JUST A SCHEME—IT IS TRUST.”
A trust that:
• Every citizen will receive their rights
• Development will be inclusive
• Delhi will transform—for the better
“YOUR CITY, YOUR RESPONSIBILITY.”
The government is doing its part—now it's our turn:

- Keep the city clean
- Follow the rules
- Participate in development

Because now, Delhi offers both rights and development—
With Modi Ji: SabkaSaath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas

Delhi's New Urban Vision: A Step Toward Transformation

Regularization of unauthorized colonies and the TOD policy are not just about legal recognition—they lay the foundation of a modern urban model where every citizen has access to better infrastructure, connectivity, and quality of life.

RESOLUTION

Over the past two decades, Delhi's population has nearly doubled. Rapid urban expansion led to unplanned development in many areas—resulting in thousands of unauthorized colonies, hundreds of slums, and numerous villages with inadequate infrastructure. For years, this reality was ignored. Now, the policy focus has shifted—from avoidance to acceptance, and from problem to practical solution.

THE DELHI OF TOMORROW: PLANNED, INCLUSIVE, CAPABLE

With support from the central government, this initiative marks a strong beginning toward transforming Delhi into a systematic and planned city. Its impact will go beyond infrastructure—it will redefine lifestyle, connectivity, and the overall urban experience. This is not just development—it is the beginning of a new identity for Delhi.

KEY TRANSFORMATIONS: BEFORE VS NOW

ASPECT	EARLIER SYSTEM	NEW SYSTEM
Beneficiaries	Limited progress, slow process	~4.5 million citizens benefitted
Conveyance Deeds	~40,000 issued	Faster process, continuous growth
Approval Process	Multi-level approvals (DDA officials)	ADM as single nodal officer
Nodal Agency	Complex multi-agency system	Revenue Department leads
Survey Process	Conducted by DDA officials	Joint survey by Patwari & Naib Tehsildar
Timeline	No fixed timeline	45 days for deed issuance
Record Management	Limited, scattered	PM-UDAY register maintained
Basis of Regularisation	Layout plan mandatory	As-is where-is basis
Coverage	Limited, complex	1,511 out of 1,731 colonies included
Restricted Areas	Lack of clarity	Clearly excludes ridge, floodplains, protected zones
Certification	Multi-agency	MCD issues certificate
Deed Issuance	Complex, time-consuming	Direct by Revenue Department
Application Process	Offline	Online via SWAGAM portal

This is more than a policy—it is a promise fulfilled.